

The Tragedy of
The Thane of Cawdor
by Kaffe Keating

Inspired by
The Tragedy of Macbeth
by William Shakespeare

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Dramatis Personae

First Sister

Second Sister

Third Sister

Duncan, King of Scotland

Malcolm, his eldest son

Donalbain, his youngest son

The Thane of **Cawdor**

Macbeth, Thane of Glamis

Lady Macbeth, his wife

Banquo

The Thane of **Ross**

Macduff, Thane of Fife

The Thane of **Lennox**

Sweno/Gunhilda, King of Norway/Sister of the King of Norway

Harthacnut, their brother

Macdonwald, a Scottish rebel

A Doctor

A Sergeant

Fifan Soldier 1

Fifan Soldier 2

A Scottish Soldier

Various other soldiers, guards and attendants

Act 1, Scene 1

Enter The Sisters

FIRST SISTER

When shall we three meet again?
In thunder, lightning or in rain?

SECOND SISTER

When the walls are closing in,
When the blood begins to thin.

THIRD SISTER

That will be ere the day has dimmed.

FIRST SISTER

Where the place?

SECOND SISTER

A royal glen.

THIRD SISTER

There to meet with King Duncan.

ALL

Foul is fair and fair is foul
Round about a king we'll prowl.

Exeunt

Act 1, Scene 2 - Court of King Duncan, Forres

Macduff is alone in the throne room

Enter Ross

ROSS

Macduff.

MACDUFF

Good Ross.

ROSS

I heard about your father.
I hear the old man died with sword in hand?

MACDUFF
He did.

ROSS
I'm sure he'd want no other end.
You're summoned here to take his title?

MACDUFF
Aye.

ROSS
You're more than equal to it. The rebellion
Has emptied Duncan's court of trusted friends;
Before their seats are filled by lesser men,
You have a chance to come and find your place.

MACDUFF
I saw another; we were stable neighbours.
The Thane of Glamis, I think.

ROSS
Macbeth has come?

MACDUFF
Perhaps with hopes to fill a seat himself?

ROSS
He has some talent as a soldier, but
His lands and wife are barren, he is past
The time when he might pass his meagre hold
Unto an heir who shares his blood. He's not
A man of consequence.

Enter Macbeth

MACDUFF
That's him.

ROSS
Macbeth!
How does The Thane of Glamis?

MACBETH

Greetings, Ross.

I do not know this man.

ROSS

This is Macduff:

My cousin, and succeeding Thane of Fife.

MACBETH

I knew your father. My condolences.

MACDUFF

I thank you humbly, sir.

MACBETH

Why are you here?

Those Eastern lands, now in your charge, are where
Th'infection of the Norsemen ails us most.

MACDUFF

Until the King has granted me my title,
The Thane of Cawdor has command in Fife
And rallies its defence.

MACBETH

Cawdor, of course.

Fret not, for older, wiser thanes than you
Have bristled in the chill of Cawdor's shadow.

MACDUFF

As soon as I am Thane, I will relieve him.

MACBETH

I'm sure the Vikings quiver at the thought.

ROSS

What brings you here to Castle Forres, Glamis?

MACBETH

I carry joyful tidings.

ROSS

Then you must

Bring with you all the joy that's left in Scotland,
You'll share it with us, surely?

MACBETH

If you wish.

My wife has given birth, I have a son.
No longer does the future of my house
Hang loosely, for the next link in the chain
Is forged and hammered strong.

ROSS

Congratulations.

MACDUFF

Your wife is well?

MACBETH

You'll see her soon yourself,
She'll bring the child here to meet the King.

ROSS

And all of us at court will share i'the joy.

Enter Duncan, Donalbain and Attendants

DUNCAN

Macduff!

MACDUFF

My liege.

DUNCAN

The circumstance allows
For but a fraction of the ceremony
The passing of so great a man deserves.
Your father was an honoured friend of mine,
I'll mourn his wisdom's loss until the day
You prove that I was right to have conferred
His title unto you. Sons, kinsmen, thanes,
And you whose places are the nearest, know
The title of the Thane of Fife will pass
Unto his eldest son, Macduff.

MACDUFF

I thank you.

DUNCAN

You'll make him proud, I'm sure.

MACDUFF

I will endeavour
To vindicate your faith as I take charge
Of Fife's defence against the Norse invaders.
I'm firm in my belief -

DUNCAN

Macduff, forgive me;
You are the Thane of Fife, but Fife's defence
Against the Viking raiders must be led
By one of more experience.

MACDUFF

But sire,
These were my father's lands and now are mine.
I humbly ask if you might reconsider,
I know I'd prove such faith a thousand-fold.

DUNCAN

You have a wife, Macduff?

MACDUFF

I do, my liege.

DUNCAN

And how did she respond when she was told
That you had made the choice to leave her side
And seek instead to be Bellona's bridegroom?
For only lying with that brutal goddess
Could satisfy such lust for war. Let Cawdor
Clear up this Viking mess for us. No doubt
You'll have your chance to prove my faith in you
By staying here in Forres by my side.

MACDUFF

Of course, my king.

Enter Lennox

LENNOX

My liege, a captain begs your audience.
He says he brings you news of the rebellion.

DUNCAN

To call that rabble a 'rebellion'
Implies a threat far greater than they pose.
They're opportunists, nothing more, who use
Our plight against the Norsemen to assert
Their fragile claims upon the Scottish throne.

LENNOX

Will you receive him, sire?

DUNCAN

Bring him in.

Enter Banquo

BANQUO

King Duncan.

DUNCAN

Who comes here?

BANQUO

My name is Banquo,
I served the Thane of Lochaber.

DUNCAN

No longer?

BANQUO

Not since he joined the rebel cause.

DUNCAN

I see.

The latest in a list of former friends
To break with king and country for a mob
Of pitiful pretenders to the crown.

BANQUO

I fear, my liege, they are a mob no longer.
They each have put aside their differences

And rallied to a single leader's banner.

DUNCAN
Whose banner is't?

BANQUO
The banner of Macdonwald.

DUNCAN
Macdonwald?

BANQUO
Aye.

DUNCAN
I never thought I'd hear
That name again.

BANQUO
It seems he has returned
From exile on the Western Isles, supplied
By kerns and gallowglasses of his own.

DUNCAN
You know this, how?

BANQUO
This missive, which I took,
Invites my erstwhile lord to join the rebels
With promises of riches, land and power,
Once they have put Macdonwald on the throne.

MACDUFF (*To Ross*)
Who is Macdonwald?

DUNCAN
You would have been a boy
When last his menace haunted Scottish shores.
Macdonwald once was close to us, was borne
From violent and rageful loins, I tried
To rein him in, to teach him calmer ways.
The troubled pup became a vicious dog,
That would not walk to heel. And then one day
He let his demons lead him to commit

An act more heinous than I could conceive.

MACDUFF

What did he do?

ROSS

Macduff -

DUNCAN

No, I will tell you.

For you should know the measure of the man.

There was a minor uprising among

Some peasant folk up in the Highland hills.

Macdonwald had been begging for a chance

To prove his service, earn my praise, and so

I sent him there to parley but, alas,

His wild and wanton nature taking o'er,

Macdonwald, in his madness, slaughtered them,

From oldest crone to brightest babe. I think

His twisted mind believed he'd only done

What I had asked of him, I cannot know.

In pity for the boy he'd been, I chose

To spare his life and exiled him beyond

Our western shores, on pain of death. It seems

He gambles with my mercy yet again.

This time, he will not find the dice so kind.

Nor will his rebel friends, who soon will learn

Why Duncan rid his kennel of this cur.

MACDUFF

Why would the rebels follow him, my liege?

DUNCAN

When men are scared, they look for guardians

As fierce as the monster that they fear.

A traveller circled by a pack of wolves

Will swing a flaming bough to fend them off;

He does not care for jealous fire's creep

When yellow eyes surround him in the dark.

I thank you, Banquo, go and rest. You have

Proved far more loyal than your former lord.

Forgive me, friends, my thoughts are waging war

And I must give their battle space and time.

Exit Duncan, Donalbain, Lennox and Attendants

MACBETH

You do the King a service, sirrah.

BANQUO

Aye,

No more than any other here would do.

MACBETH

Such loyalty, I hope, will be rewarded.

BANQUO

A loyal act should be its own reward.

MACBETH

It should, indeed, but rarely is it so.

Exit Banquo

ROSS

I know not which of Scotland's two diseases,
The Viking or the rebel, now is worse.
Macbeth, you did not have a chance to share
Your joyful news with Duncan, I am sure
It would provide a physic for his ills.
He walks the glen beyond the castle walls,
At times like this when he is full of thought.
Go on, and I will spread your news at court:
"In Dunsinane, a mother's newly blessed;
She smiles upon a baby at her breast."

MACDUFF

Congratulations, Glamis. I am a father,
I tell you, there's no greater joy I've known.

MACBETH

I thank you, both.

Exit Macbeth

MACDUFF

His child has my pity.

ROSS

Why?

MACDUFF

I fear

He too will have his title taken from him
When Glamis no longer walks upon the earth.

ROSS

You're Thane of Fife.

MACDUFF

In name, but Cawdor keeps
Command of all my lands? It's no surprise,
When slights like this are tossed so freely out,
That loyalty is tested.

ROSS

Patience, cousin.

The sea churn this rebellion has brought on
Has pulled new thanes, still faithful, to the surface
And swept some others out into the deep.
We two, like mariners, can ride this tide
And drop our anchors here at Duncan's side.

Exeunt

Act 1, Scene 3 - A bloody battlefield near Fife

Enter Malcolm with a Sergeant

MALCOLM

You saw him here?

SERGEANT

Aye, he was fighting Sweno.

MALCOLM

King Sweno fought beside his men?

SERGEANT

He did,
And fiercely too.

MALCOLM

You recognised him?

SERGEANT

Aye,

He had his armour on; across the chest
Twin dragons, red and black. It's rare indeed
To see those dragon's eyes and live to tell it.
I fear the Thane of Cawdor -

MALCOLM

We will find him.

Cawdor?

SERGEANT

Ho! Thane of Cawdor?

MALCOLM

Cawdor?

CAWDOR

Here!

Enter Cawdor, wounded

MALCOLM

He's wounded, fetch him surgeons.

SERGEANT

Yes, sir.

Exit Sergeant

CAWDOR

Malcolm,

You are unhurt?

MALCOLM

I am.

CAWDOR

That's good.

MALCOLM

I stayed
Up there, upon the cliff, just like you said.
You're wounded.

CAWDOR

I've never seen so many Norsemen,
Their host must be ten times what I had thought.
From where you were, what was your reckoning?

MALCOLM

Some twenty-thousand, maybe.

CAWDOR

Such a force
Has never stormed our shores before.

MALCOLM

What happened, Cawdor?

CAWDOR

They sprang a trap.
We spied a modest band of Viking raiders
And chased them down to lower ground and then,
Too late, I saw that they'd surrounded us
In numbers greater than I could believe.
They had us in a snare of shields, encircled,
And should have killed us all, but they withdrew.

MALCOLM

I saw them, when their calling horns rang out
They made a swift retreat.

CAWDOR

I should be dead.

MALCOLM

You fought King Sweno?

CAWDOR

What?

MALCOLM

The Sergeant said

He saw you fighting Sweno, did he risk
His life in open battle?

CAWDOR

Aye, he did.

Across the field, not feet from me, I saw him.
He swung his greataxe through my men just like
A farmer reaping corn at harvest time.
His flaxen mane was knotted into cords
Congealèd long with blood, his icy gaze
Was fixed on me, it chilled my living blood.
He cut a path towards me, striking down
A dozen Scots and ere I had the chance
To lift my blade, he knocked me to the mud.
He raised his axe, I made my peace with death,
But then, a pike was thrust into his chest.
It pierced his armour through a dragon's eye,
I looked up from the dragon to the king
And when I found those icy eyes again,
Pulled wide with shock, I felt them freeze me fast.
An age of quiet calm passed by us both,
Before the battle pulled us from the pause.
My pikeman saviour's head was taken off
By one of Sweno's guard who bore his king
Away upon his back beyond my sight.

MALCOLM

Was Sweno slain?

CAWDOR

The wound was deep.

Enter a Messenger at a distance, cloaked.

MALCOLM

Cawdor,

I see a man approaching us.

CAWDOR

Hold fast!

What are you?

MESSENGER

I am one who brings a message.

You are the leader of these Scotsmen?

CAWDOR

Aye.

MESSENGER

What is your name?

CAWDOR

I am the Thane of Cawdor.

Who is your message from?

MESSENGER

From Sweno King.

MALCOLM

He lives, then?

CAWDOR

Hush. What is the message, sirrah?

MESSENGER

You have fought well, like drengir, and King Sweno

Has found in you a foe he can respect.

Therefore, he offers you his rarest boon;

His mercy. He will let you leave this place

With your surviving men but you must take

A message to your king. This, Sweno says:

There can be peace in Scotland if King Duncan

Agrees to make a gift of lands to Norway,

So he might settle in these Eastern holds.

The land we now command will serve us well.

Give us these lands, and we will give you peace.

CAWDOR

King Sweno makes this offer, so you claim?

I saw him skewered through the chest. His hide

Was punctured like a boar. How can we know

That Sweno still draws breath enough to pass

This message on to you?

The Messenger removes their cloak. They have long, blonde hair and blue eyes and they are wearing a chest plate with two dragons on it, one of which has been pierced through the eye.

MALCOLM
Is that -

CAWDOR
It is.

SWENO
My hide, you see, is thick.
Now, go and tell your King that you saw Sweno:
You saw his army's magnitude, you knew
The limit of his mercy and you heard
The only time that he would speak of peace.

CAWDOR
I will convey your offer unto Duncan,
But since you have correctly judged my people
As proud and hardy fighters, you must know
That such demands will not be keenly heard.
What can you offer us, King Sweno, for
These lands that you desire?

SWENO
I offer you your lives.

CAWDOR
They're ours already.

SWENO
Until they aren't.

CAWDOR
Indeed, but once they're gone
We're in no state to miss them.

SWENO
True, indeed.
What would you ask of Sweno, Thane of Cawdor?

CAWDOR
There is a group of traitors in our lands
Who broke their bonds of fealty to Duncan
Soon after your invasion; opportunists,
Who pose no major threat to Duncan's rule,
But are an irritation, none-the-less.

If you might offer to exterminate
This irksome infestation it would help
Persuade him to give up these lands you want.

SWENO
King Duncan is too weak to -

CAWDOR
No, not weak.
The ease with which he could destroy this foe
Is proven by his long procrastination.
I know he would appreciate the gesture.

SWENO
Tell Duncan that this can be done.

CAWDOR
I will,
And I will pass your message to my King.

SWENO
We will be here, awaiting Duncan's answer.

Exit Sweno

MALCOLM
Was that King Sweno?

CAWDOR
Aye. If it was not,
A thief has stol'n his eyes.

MALCOLM
Why did he come
Across the field alone?

CAWDOR
I cannot tell.
There's something strange afoot.

MALCOLM
Let's call a rider,
To run him down before he makes it back.

CAWDOR

And let loose twenty-thousand vengeful Vikings
Who, leaderless and aimless, then, would burn
The Lowlands all to ash?

MALCOLM

With such a force,
Why does he offer peace?

CAWDOR

I do not think
It's possible he comprehends how fragile
Your father's rule is now, for if he did,
He'd crush us underfoot.

MALCOLM

Perhaps that pikeman
Has shaken his resolve?

CAWDOR

Perhaps. If so,
He did not show it in his countenance.

MALCOLM

What happens now?

CAWDOR

We ride to see the King,
And pray that he will greet the news we bring.

Exeunt

Act 1, Scene 4 - A glen outside Forres Castle

Enter Duncan

DUNCAN

I am confined between two closing walls;
Norse raiders to the East and my own kin,
Scots rebels in the West and 'twixt the two
How can my rule survive this double danger?
My allies, I must keep within my gaze
Lest into foes, behind my back, they're made.

The Sisters appear

Who are these women? Three of you. What, ho?
Well come then, speak, if speech is known to you.

THREE SISTERS

All hail, Duncan! Hail to thee, King of Scotland!

DUNCAN

You know me then, yet seem to pose no threat.
If you are of this land you are my subjects,
My duty is to hear what you request.
What do you wish to say unto your king?

THREE SISTERS

Thou wilt see, we sisters three
Will show the future unto thee.

FIRST SISTER

Duncan, ye who has the crown
Though there are those who'd cast thee down
Once the battle's lost and won,
Thy crown will gild thy eldest son.

DUNCAN

If I were sure that this would come to pass,
Upon my death, then, finally, I could calm
The anxious greyhounds racing in my head.
But though this soothes my aching brain, that's not
Enough to prove a divination true.

SECOND SISTER

Duncan, ye who's crownèd king:
The next to wear that golden ring
Will be the one to bear the knife
That stabs your heart and takes your life.

DUNCAN

But what is this? You tell me first that Malcolm,
My son, my eldest boy, will wear my crown
But, now that he will kill me for it? Ha,
Though I suspect you wish to eke out tears,
These maddening ramblings rather make me laugh.

I wonder where you nab this notion from!
You bring more gloom than she, your sister brings -
I'm sure I'd rather hear more speech from her.

THIRD SISTER

Duncan, served by many thanes,
But one who will be thy life's bane.
The Thane of Cawdor, I foresee,
Will prove a traitor unto thee.

DUNCAN

Oh, Cawdor? Really, this is best of all.
The Thane of Cawdor, traitor! I have raised him
From pup to loyal hound and he has sat
With patience and devotion by my side
For all his life. No, this is laughable.

FIRST SISTER

Duncan!

SECOND SISTER

Duncan!

THIRD SISTER

Duncan!

DUNCAN

With one ear would I hear you, I have two.
What is it you would now accost them with?

FIRST SISTER

A single foe will form from two

SECOND SISTER

And when they have encircled you

THIRD SISTER

The only son of bold Macbeth

FIRST SISTER

Will bring you victory in death.

SECOND SISTER

So look to him, when all seems lost

THIRD SISTER

But know that you will pay the cost.

THREE SISTERS

So all hail the wise King Duncan
Duncan, the wise king, all hail!

DUNCAN

Now, this moves from the comic to the cruel.
It's well known in my lands that poor Macbeth
The Thane of Glamis, my kinsman, is long-cursed
To suffer in his quiet castle, childless.
His wife, a godly woman, never has
Been gifted with the sound of crying babe.
It's proof on proof that all you say is nonsense.
Now vanish from my sight!

The Sisters vanish

And so they do.

These sisters seem more gifted in the trick
Of hiding in the light than setting forth
The time ahead and what will come to be.

Enter Macbeth

MACBETH

My liege?

DUNCAN

Who's there?

MACBETH

A friend.

DUNCAN

Macbeth! There were
Three people, maybe women, did they pass you?

MACBETH

When, now, my liege?

DUNCAN

Yes, now.

MACBETH

No, I saw nothing.

Are you all right, my King? Your cheeks are pale
Your hands are shaking and your beaded brow
Is furrowed like a field that's fresh for sewing.
Was someone here?

DUNCAN

I thought there could have been,
The half-light tricks my tired eyes, I'm sure.
What brings you here to Forres, Glamis?

MACBETH

Sire,

I come with news from Castle Dunsinane -
My wife has given birth. A boy, he lives.
He joined us early, two weeks, slightly more,
It seems that he was eager for the world.
He breathes and sleeps and cries and he has all
His fingers and his toes. I think I see
More of his mother in his face but she
Insists she sees my eyes in his. Who knows?
So yes, my king, I've come to tell you first
You, who so oft has listened to our worries
And calmed our fears, and told us to keep faith;
Well, faith rewarded us a thousandfold.
My wife will bring the child here to court,
As soon as she is strong enough to travel.
The birth itself was not an easy one,
The heavens wrestled with us for him but
He's here and you will meet him soon enough.

DUNCAN

A son?

MACBETH

A son, my liege.

DUNCAN

Most wonderful.

I thought I might be standing in my grave
With dark earth pressing in on me but now

I see this glint of light and it is clear
That this is but a tunnel from whose dark
We will emerge into a future brightness.
Now get you gone, you must have ridden long
To bring this news, now it is brought.

MACBETH

My liege.

Exit Macbeth

DUNCAN

"The only son of bold Macbeth"
If what they speak is true, and this boy's death
Will win some future victory, my reign
Will surely last until he is a man,
A fearsome fighter like his fierce father.
O unfamiliar lightness of relief!
What else? The first one prophesied that Malcolm
Would wear my crown, but then the second said
The next to wear the crown would end my life.
From this must I deduce that my own son,
My firstborn son, will kill me? But the third:
She told me Cawdor will turn traitor. No!
Unthinkable, I don't believe it. Yet,
Macbeth has sired a son.
A fortune fanciful as anything
That was foretold and then, within a breath,
Fate proved it true. My son looks up to Cawdor,
He often follows him in thought and theory,
And if they did not think me fit to lead,
Perhaps it is not past belief they'd join
Together in a plan of regicide;
Have Malcolm take my place upon the throne
With Cawdor at his back, not hound but master:
His puppet strings wound round the young King's wrists.
Oh pause, you quick and lively mind of mine.
I count the crop before the seeds are sown,
These fates predicted are not writ in stone.

Exeunt

Act 2, Scene 1 - Dunsinane Castle

Enter Lady Macbeth, holding a baby and reading a letter

LADY MACBETH (*Reading*)

"The King was thrilled to hear of our blessing and looks forward to your arrival here in Castle Forres with great anticipation. It's clear that his fondness for you has not diminished. He told me our news was like a glint of light at the end of a long tunnel; a promise of hope for the future, and so it is, my love.

No longer must we look back over our shoulders, wary of ambition's shadow moving in the half-light. But you must bring the child here as soon as you have strength.

There is change in Duncan's court; the King has lost many to this rebellion whom he once thought loyal. The space they have vacated can now be filled by those who choose to take it up.

My eagerness to bathe in the light of our child's arrival is matched only by my longing to have you by my side. Though the world seems steeped in tumult and fear, I know that we have brighter days yet to come.

Lay it to thy heart, and farewell."

(To the baby)

Our days ahead were sunless, grey and dull
But with your coming, so the blinding dawn
Breaks o'er the hills and fills our eyes with tears.
O do not cry, my love, no, do not cry;
The tears I speak of, these are tears of joy
Yet, even as your mewling howls ring out,
They're sweet as any music I have heard -
Nay, sweeter, for the notes that land upon
My willing ears deliver proof of breath
Within your lungs and of the living fire
That burns within your tiny, beating heart.
O, up and down and up and down and up
And down and up and down and up and down.
Though I have never known my heart to be so full,
My love is now fermenting into fear.
Delight distills to dread, contaminates
My arteries and pumps it through my body.
In inky darkness, feigning sleep, I beg
To hear the music of your living cries
So that my terror briefly might be lifted.
This is the debt I pay and happily so.

But now we must to Forres and the King,
To show the world your father's line is strong.
I'll hold you close, here at my woman's breast,
And feel the vital beating in your chest.

Exeunt

Act 2, Scene 2 - Court of King Duncan, Forres

Enter Cawdor and Malcolm

CAWDOR
He knows that we've arrived?

MALCOLM
I have sent word.
You have been quiet.

CAWDOR
In voice, but not in thought.

MALCOLM
Tonight my father plans to hold a feast
In celebration of a newborn heir.

CAWDOR
Convenient distraction.

MALCOLM
I suppose.
I wonder what the kitchen plans to serve.
I know not what might sate my father's hunger,
Much less the thanes' at court. Were I his cook,
And had to feed so many mouths and cater
For such a range of tastes and preference,
I would not risk an unfamiliar meal.
A recipe from foreign lands, I think,
Would please the table less than one I knew
Would fill them with familiar comfort.

CAWDOR
You saw the Viking army, Malcolm.

MALCOLM

Yes.

CAWDOR

You saw the way their longship sails eclipsed
The line of the horizon from the cliffs.
I'd dearly love to feed the King the feast
He wants to serve his court, but how could I,
Now knowing that the meat is rank and rotten?
Besides, King Sweno has agreed to lend
His men and arms in putting down the rebels,
This should provide the pot with finer flavour.

MALCOLM

But what if -

CAWDOR

Duncan trusts me Malcolm and,
When you are king, you too will learn to value
The men who tell the truths you need to hear.

MALCOLM

You speak as if I have been named his heir.

CAWDOR

Men pass their titles to their sons.

MALCOLM

Not always.

He has not named me Prince of Cumberland.

CAWDOR

He'll name you, I would bet my horse.

MALCOLM

Would you?

You're like a son to him, he's said as much.

CAWDOR

It's not the same.

MALCOLM

But if he named you -

CAWDOR

Malcolm -

MALCOLM

If Duncan named you Prince of Cumberland,
And told the court you were to be his heir,
You'd see my shoulders fall, but not with woe.
That slowly tightening golden band would crush
My brittle skull until it cracked in half
To leave behind an empty shell, which then
Could easily be crushed beneath a boot.
My father sees the weakness in my soul,
He sent me off to Fife with you in hope
This parchèd sponge might somehow catch a splash
O'the courage, valour, leadership and skill
O'erflowing from the son he wished was his.

Enter Duncan, Donalbain, Ross, Macduff, Banquo, Lennox and Attendants

DUNCAN

Cawdor.

CAWDOR

My liege.

DUNCAN

You have arrived.

MALCOLM

Father.

DUNCAN

And you return my son to me. I hope
You've schooled him well in war against the Norse?
Since you return so soon I must assume
You either bring us news of victory,
Or that our Eastern flank is overrun.
Are there more guests arriving in your wake?

CAWDOR

No, sadly sire, I bring no Norsemen north
To enjoy your hospitality today.
Though if I had, you doubtless could have fed 'em;
Where are your other thanes, my liege?

MALCOLM

It's true, my liege, I saw -

DUNCAN

Continue, Cawdor.

CAWDOR

Alone, we stood against this great Colossus.
Though many counselled swift retreat, I knew
We had a chance to build a meagre well
O'er which King Sweno first would have to climb,
Before he could run roughshod over Scotland.
And so, outnumbered hugely as we were,
Surrounded on all sides, with little hope,
I had my men stand ground against their charge.
When wading through the fight, I spied their King -

DUNCAN

King Sweno fought among them?

CAWDOR

Aye, he led 'em,
He bellowed out for blood below his banner
And showed no fear, all was ferocity.
Across the field, not feet from me, I saw
His greataxe swinging through my men and so
I cut a path towards him, striking down
A dozen or so Vikings, 'til I faced him.
We fought for what felt like an age. His eyes
Were icy cold with bluest hate and bore
Into my own like frozen shards. But when,
He brought his axe up high in frenzied rage,
I spied an opening in his guard and thrust
My hewnèd steel into his chest, and pierced
His armour plate below the heart.

DUNCAN

He's dead?

CAWDOR

Ere I could take his head, one of his men,
A trollish giant, took his body up,
And carried him away, beyond my sight.

And then, the miracle: their hollering horns
Commanded their retreat. We watched the Norsemen
Limp back behind their lines into the night
And so, in muffled hope, we quit the field
And tended to our wounded and our dead.
Then, from the gloom, approached a lonely figure.
He held no warlike instrument; his hands
Were held up high above his head and thus
He picked his way across the littered ground.
His face was shielded fully from my gaze,
He had his hood pulled low and stood so that
His form was swallowed by the rising sun;
Just as a hunting falcon will recruit
Apollo as an ally 'gainst its prey.
Though I could see no face, his voice rang clear,
He claimed to bring a message from King Sweno -

DUNCAN

Intrepid messenger indeed, to bring
King Sweno's message from the afterlife.

CAWDOR

I shouted back across the bloody field,
His King was surely either dead or dying,
And dead kings' words are precious little use
To those who still abide among the living,
But then the messenger removed his hood.
Two sapphires glittered 'gainst a golden mane;
Those same two icy eyes that locked with mine
But hours before now pierced them once again,
Just as my sword had pierced his armoured trunk.

ROSS

You're saying that this messenger was Sweno?

CAWDOR

I am.

DUNCAN

You're sure?

CAWDOR

I'm certain, for he wore
That selfsame armour which I'd pierced, the hole

Displayed in proud defiance, and those eyes;
I'll ne'er forget them 'til the day I die.

MACBETH

So where's his head?

CAWDOR

Atop his shoulders, still.

ROSS

The King of Norway, stood alone before you,
Unarmed and wounded and you let him go?

CAWDOR

Ah Ross, if only you'd been there, I'm sure
This warlike vigour which, Achilles-like,
You must possess in order not to fathom
The depth of one's fatigue after a battle,
May well have seen the Viking horde destroyed.
Although, had you been in the mud with us,
And, by heroic instinct, leapt to take
The Norse King's life I would have bid you pause.
He'd crossed the field alone, unarmed, to seek
A way to end this war and if I'd cut
This head off, I have no doubt that another
Would now be writhing in its place set firm
On seeking bloody vengeance. I don't know
What time Sweno has left yet, but I am sure
A wounded man is easier to bend
Than one who reaps the tilth of ample strength.

DUNCAN

You say he brought a message, Cawdor?

CAWDOR

Yes.

Although not fatal, I believe my blow,
May well have been the thing to cow the King
Enough to make this proposition:
He'll call an end to his invasion,
Declare a peace between the Norse and Scots,
If you agree to cede the lands he holds,
From Tay to Forth, from Lomond to the sea,
To Norway's single rule.

DUNCAN

This Viking, who has sailed here from abroad,
From lands that he already calls his own,
Who's scarred our shores with violence and fire,
The sparks of which have lit a rebel flame
Which burns still brighter by the passing day,
Expects us now to freely make a gift
Of ancient Scottish land? He might as well
Request a gift of flesh cut from my body,
I'd rather have a butcher slice away
The muscle from my limbs than let a blade
Of Scottish grass be traded off for free.

CAWDOR

I could not be more firmly in agreement.
I told the Norseman this was laughable;
In order for my king to contemplate
Permitting even one Norweyan subject
The space to pitch a single tent we would
Require something in exchange, and so
I told him if he used his mighty army
To cleanse your kingdom of the rebels, then
You might allow these settlers space. And now
I learn that this once disparate list of traitors
Have multiplied the dreadful threat they pose
By choosing to align behind Macdonwald,
Which makes me doubly glad Sweno agreed.

DUNCAN

You say that he agreed?

CAWDOR

Indeed, my liege.

ROSS

And you believe he has no other motive?
Desire for peace has blinded you, it seems.

MACBETH

It's blindness that he seeks. His eyes are spent;
I've seen such sunken emptiness before,
They're now too full of war to bear the sight
Of fallen comrades' steaming innards tainting

The misty chill. He'd split his ears to end
The screams, the crack of blade on bone. He fears
That vault of memory, where he's locked away
The flashing agony of war, will burst
And overspill with shredded flesh, with ghosts
Of foes put down and friends unsaved. So now
He seeks to end these grim deposits, ere
The strongroom in his mind is forced agape.
He had a chance to end his enemy.
He should be showing us his head, instead
As birds do, he has swallowed and ingested
These rotting words of peace and vomits up
Regurgitated fiction down our throats.

CAWDOR

The Thane of Glamis has found his voice at last.
I've always known him quiet as a mouse.
Macbeth, from whence is this new courage borne?

MACBETH

You doubt my courage?

CAWDOR

Only as much
As you throw doubt on mine.

MACBETH

You dare -

DUNCAN

My thanes.

I stand with enemies at either hand.
Let not the allies in my bosom bicker,
So easily forgetting they are friends.

CAWDOR

Hear me, all:
A band of mad barbarians, this is not.
They're well led, they're well armed and they are many;
In might and number, they exceed us both.
Yet by some miracle, their king not only
Has offered us a chance to keep our lives
He has agreed to rid us of Macdonwald!
We take the deal, give up some land, and keep

King Duncan, wise and honoured, on our throne,
Or choose to flip a double-headed coin:
King Sweno on one side, who, when he learned
How weak we are, would then be free to take
Whichever lands he pleased, far more than those
He currently requests, and on the other:
King Macdonwald, how does that greet the ear?
You baulk at losing Scottish lands, my thanes,
But what of Scotland's soul? Ta'en by a tyrant:
A man who, time again, has proved to be
Ambitious, bloodthirsty, dishonourable
The opposite in every way to he
We, blessed and thankful, now have for our king.
Although the fabric scratches at your skin,
I tell you all a truth that must be worn:
There is no way for us to truly win.
The choice is compromise or grim defeat.

ROSS

And what of those to whom these lands belong?
What fate awaits the Scots who, all their lives,
Have toiled in this corner of our garden?

MACBETH

Macduff? Your silence here astounds me.
This truce would rob you of your father's lands.

MACDUFF

This does concern me, Cawdor. Though you are
The steward of my father's lands at present
I'm now the Thane of Fife.

CAWDOR

I understand.
But you would not give up your lands, Macduff.
They, peacefully, request some space to settle.
So Norse and Scot, both side by side might live.

MACDUFF

I don't - but no, how can that -

MACBETH

I wonder what
The Vikings promised you for moving us

To give our lands away to foreign scum
With no sword drawn and no blood offered up
In their defence.

CAWDOR

You call me traitor?

ROSS

Why

With twenty-thousand soldiers, as you say,
Does Sweno not demand the whole of Scotland?

CAWDOR

I have no doubt this was his plan before
He felt the Scottish steel between his ribs.
This gave him pause in his ambitions and
I now believe he'd rather have a Scot
Who's friendly to the Norsemen on the throne
Than somehow rule unruly Scots, himself.

ROSS

A friendly Scot on Scotland's throne you say?
You've spoken of ambition; how disastrous
Another's rule would be. Perhaps you think
That you would suit some gold upon the brow?

CAWDOR

My liege, these base and baseless accusations
Distract us from the matter here at hand.
You may see traitors everywhere, my thanes,
But Duncan knows my true allegiance.

MACBETH

Once we open

Our gates for Sweno's wooden horse it will
Roll forth into our country. From its belly
Will burning, raping pillagers burst forth.
The lands are not for settling, they're for building
A base from which to let loose an invasion.
There's no true Scotsman, Cawdor, in this land,
Who would allow his enemy to walk
Past all of his defences on a promise
That once he has, he'll do no harm to him.

ROSS

Were you to take this course of action, sir,
It would no doubt be seen by the rebellion
As proof of their convictions and so swell
Already growing numbers.

MACBETH

Oh, but Ross,
Do not forget, once we have duly given
This Sweno what he wants he said he'd kindly
Dispatch Macdonwald for us, isn't that
The deal he offered Cawdor?

ROSS

So he said.

CAWDOR

You have two choices, Duncan, you can fight,
And make your Scotland bleed, or you can let
This Sweno have his lands and end this war.
What say you, sire?

DUNCAN

The Romans Legions conquered all of Europe
And built the greatest empire of the world.
They'd taken England, Spain and Greece and Gaul,
The tribes of Germany could not resist them,
Their empire spread this far but when they reached
The edge of Scotland, then their march was halted.
They turned and ran and built a wall behind them,
Such was the fear our forefathers provoked.
This Scottish spirit now I call upon:
There'll be no parley with these Norse invaders.
We'll drive them o'er the cliff tops of our coasts
And they will drag their shivering, wasted trunks
From off their splintered ships and pray the waves
Propel their bobbing bodies through the surf
Which, darkened by their bloody stumps, will stain
The beaches of the wasteland they call home
For fifty generations from today.
If their descendants dare to misremember,
The tales of horror told to them as boys
When they refused to eat their rancid fish,
Of how the Scotsmen sliced their pappies up

And sent them rowing home with oars in teeth,
That sanguine sand of Norway would remind 'em,
And any shipwright who was told to build
A longboat Scotland-bound would crack his tools
To save his fellow men from horrid slaughter.
These Norsemen aren't the first to raid our shores
And history will use them as a warning
When next a foreign king has dared to think
He has the men to lay the Saltire low.

CAWDOR

My liege -

DUNCAN

And as for you, I hope to God
It is your mind you left behind in Fife,
And not your honour, so to counsel me
To crawl to Sweno on my belly, begging
That he dispatch our enemies for us.

CAWDOR

I only tell the truth, my king -

DUNCAN

To think,
I sent my son to learn the art of war
From one who could not even kill a foe
Alone, unarmed and wounded who delivered
His wasted trunk unto him freely!

CAWDOR

What?
Have you not heard a word I've said? Where is
The thoughtful, wise and patient Duncan?
From where was borne this warmongering imposter
Who thinks a bellowed, blustering diatribe
Can stand against an army thousands-strong?

DUNCAN

You go against my word? Do you rebel?

CAWDOR

If fate would have me serve a foolish brute,
I might as well rebel and join Macdonwald!

MALCOLM

Cawdor!

DUNCAN

Duncan, served by many thanes:
There is one who'll prove thy bane.

CAWDOR

My liege -

DUNCAN

I'd never have believed them, there it is.

CAWDOR

My liege, I did not mean - I meant to say -

DUNCAN

I sentence Cawdor to imprisonment
Here in our castle's bowels 'til we decide
The punishment this treachery deserves.

CAWDOR

What treachery? My liege I only seek
To help you make the wisest choice you can.

DUNCAN

You have colluded with him!

CAWDOR

I have not
Served any other King than you -

DUNCAN

Silence.
We will not give you further audience.
Seize him and keep him locked up tight below.

Cawdor is held by guards

MALCOLM

No, father, please, you can't -

DUNCAN

Let us speak soon.

ROSS

There is much to discuss.

Exit Macbeth

MACDUFF

The Thane of Cawdor fought and bled for Fife,
He's served King Duncan all his life, and now
We're certain he's a traitor?

ROSS

I would think
You would be grateful that suspicion falls
Upon the one who urged the King to give
Your land and birthright to the Norse invaders.

MACDUFF

It's Cawdor who has kept my father's lands
From falling into violent Viking hands.

ROSS

And now he's in a dungeon. You must learn:
This is a field of battle too, and one
On which more land and honour may be lost
With but a single, poorly chosen word
Than in a decade fighting man to man.

Exit Ross and Macduff

DONALBAIN

Why do you speak against our father, Malcolm?

MALCOLM

He strikes against a steadfast, trusted ally
And somehow sees rebellion in friendship.

DONALBAIN

Our father's wise, he knows what should be done.

MALCOLM

He calls the Thane of Cawdor traitor!

He has not called
For Cawdor's death, but only his detention.
Displays of such dissent can't go unanswered
At times when loyalty is so unsure.

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Exit DONALBAIN

MALCOLM

Among my father's meagre rump of allies
Are precious few who offer him such counsel
That dares to challenge what he may decree.
Although the King cannot tell friend from foe,
I'll force him to remember what he knows.

Exeunt

Act 3, Scene 1 - Outside a chamber in Duncan's Castle, Forres

Enter Duncan

DUNCAN

If I believe the sisters tell the truth,
Then execution should be done on Cawdor.
In doing so I'd cut off my right hand
To save my body from a worse infection.
But if this illness is misdiagnosed,
If I have been deceived or have mistaken
The meaning in their maddened murmurings,
Then I would willingly have maimed myself
For nothing in exchange, but pain and sorrow.
I hold the cleaver high above my wrist,
It's keen edge glinting in the flickering light,
But then the air between the flesh and blade
Solidifies and holds my arm aloft,
In rigid indecision. Soft. Who's there?

Enter Lady Macbeth with a baby in her arms

LADY MACBETH

My liege, I beg your pardon.

DUNCAN

Not at all.

LADY MACBETH

My husband said that you had left the chamber.

DUNCAN
Has he asked for me?

LADY MACBETH
Well, I heard him mention -
I'm sure you need some time here for yourself.
I'll leave you.

DUNCAN
No, your company is welcome.
I stand alone, but crowded by my thoughts;
Their company is far less kind than yours.

LADY MACBETH
Well then, if I can prove a brief distraction,
That is the smallest service I can do.
You show us such benevolence, my liege,
To feast us here and celebrate our son,
Especially in such troubled times as these.

DUNCAN
In times of trouble, every thread of joy
That's woven in the tapestry is one
That keeps our hope alive.
How is our guest of honour?

LADY MACBETH
He is...

DUNCAN
What?

LADY MACBETH
I do not wish to burden you.

DUNCAN
What burden?

LADY MACBETH
My liege, I thank you, but it's nothing more
Than every parent must be subject to.

DUNCAN
You're speaking to a parent, what's the matter?

As soon as I'd learned how to be a father,
I had to learn to be a mother, too.
The chance to help someone in need would be
A gift that you'd be giving at a time
When, though a king, I am myself a subject
And all my power leaves me powerless.
You are my subject, yes?

LADY MACBETH

Of course I am.

DUNCAN

It is my duty, then, to give you aid.
If not that, then at least a listening ear.

LADY MACBETH

We've tried so long, and lost so many times.
I have no way of knowing what is normal.
His breathing, can you hear? It rattles, no?
He seems to struggle sometimes and look, now,
His breath is rapid, in and out like that.
It can't be normal, can it?

DUNCAN

I don't know.

LADY MACBETH

He wasn't very big when he was born,
I thought he'd grow but, see? He's pale and wan.
I cannot tell, perhaps he has, but this:
This breathing quickly, like he's doing now.
I try to find a quiet corner for him
To keep him calm; the feasting and the drinking
Is far more noise and motion than he's used to.
I am exhausted by the constant thoughts
My mind bombards me with: 'Is he alive?
Is he too cold? Too hot? Or is this just
Some dream I'm trapped within?' At night, I wake,
He's crying in the night, I go to him
And then I wake again: I'm back in bed.
I feel at any moment I'll wake up
To find that I was dreaming. Maybe now,
I'll wake and think: I dreamt I saw the King.
My liege. I'm sorry, I forget myself.

DUNCAN

No, not at all.

LADY MACBETH

I'll leave you now, forgive me.

DUNCAN

No, please, stay.

I cannot offer much. Although, there is...

LADY MACBETH

Sire?

DUNCAN

What do you fear, my lady, most of all?

LADY MACBETH

I fear my child will die.

DUNCAN

And so you share

The angst of every parent who has known

The grasp of tiny hands around a finger.

I think you worry needlessly.

LADY MACBETH

You do?

DUNCAN

Your son will grow into a fearsome fighter,

Just like his father.

LADY MACBETH

I wish I was so sure.

DUNCAN

I'm sure.

LADY MACBETH

Forgive me, sire, I recognise

You want to ease my burdens and I thank -

DUNCAN

Some days ago, I walked beyond the walls,
Alone, as is my habit, when the mist
Revealed the shape of three strange women to me.
They spoke in unison and told me things
That had not come to pass. Now, I must say,
At first I thought their speeches to be madness -
The ramblings of collected, damaged minds -
But then their gift of foresight was confirmed.
They'd spoken of the 'son of bold Macbeth'.
I thought that this was proof they peddled lies,
I had an understanding of your trouble,
And yet, as soon as they departed, who
Arrived to pass along his joyful news?
Your husband, frothing full of pride and joy.
The women told me that your son, one day,
Would die to bring a victory in Scotland.
If they should be believed, you have no need
To worry 'til your son's of fighting age,
His death will come in battle, not in crib.
And even once he's old enough to fight
That does not mean that death is close at hand,
For fighting age is not so short a time:
I still believe that even I can swing
A sword and ride a horse when need arises,
And I have lived a life of length my lady.

LADY MACBETH

You say these women told you this?

DUNCAN

They did.

And other things, besides.

LADY MACBETH

What things?

DUNCAN

Ah, those,

Are for my ears alone.

LADY MACBETH

But did they speak,

More of my son?

DUNCAN

No, all they said of him
I have passed on to you.
This may not bring you comfort -

LADY MACBETH

No, it does.
I thank you, sire. I'll take my leave of you.
I need to see if I can make him sleep.

DUNCAN

A drop of whisky used to work for Malcolm.

LADY MACBETH

Where is your son, my liege?

DUNCAN

Forgive me, lady,
My eldest son will not be joining us.
The news of Cawdor's treachery has rocked him.
They've long been close, he'll need to take some time.

LADY MACBETH

I see.

DUNCAN

Don't let me keep you.

LADY MACBETH

Thank you, sire. Farewell.

Exit Lady Macbeth

DUNCAN

O, what took hold of me? I couldn't stop.
What must she think? What will she say? Will she
Repeat this to her husband? If she does,
He'll want to know what else the sisters said.
Or will they simply think me lunatic?
So old and gullible, he's taken in
By weird and rambling women in the glen?
I'm confident Macbeth, for now, is loyal
And with the place at my right hand vacated,
Perhaps it's right to bring him closer in.

Exit Duncan

Act 3, Scene 2 - A Dungeon in Forres Castle

Cawdor is alone, imprisoned

Enter Malcolm

MALCOLM

My time is short, nobody knows I'm here.

CAWDOR

The guards?

MALCOLM

They're plied with drink. It wasn't hard,
They were the only two of all the men
Who missed the feast and jealously they quaffed
The wine I brought to them, which I had laced
With a drug for restless sleepers.

CAWDOR

Devious.

MALCOLM

Perhaps as devious as your report.

CAWDOR

I told King Duncan everything I knew.

MALCOLM

You lied about your fight with Sweno.

CAWDOR

Well,

A fearsome reputation is a thing
That must be cultivated and protected.
We are the stories that we tell, we make
The truth we wish to live.

MALCOLM

Well if you wish

To live another day, we must be quick.
The King will soon be forced to make a choice;
Your life in limbo weakens his resolve.
I fear he'll settle on your execution,
Believing it the only way to quiet
The voices of the friends he needs to keep.
Though you might be a weaver of the truth,
I know you and I know you are no traitor.

Malcolm unlocks Cawdor's cage

You must be gone, the feast is nearly over.

CAWDOR
Your father will suspect your hand in this.

MALCOLM
Then he will know that I protect my friends.
Now go, I don't know where, but somewhere far.
I hope you will find peace and safety there.

CAWDOR
I don't know what -

MALCOLM
Now go!

CAWDOR
I thank you, Malcolm.

Exit CAWDOR

MALCOLM
Were I more blindly hopeful I would stay,
Feign innocence when this was brought to light,
But hope would serve me poorly in this case.
My father must be witness to my fealty,
I must set out to prove my worthiness;
Of Cawdor I've deprived him, in his stead,
I'll bring the King Macdonwald's severed head.

Exeunt

Act 3, Scene 3 - A quay on the bank of the River Findhorn, outside Forres

Enter Cawdor

CAWDOR

This river flows past Forres to the sea,
From there, away from Scotland's shores to freedom.
I will be free to choose my name; no longer
Will I be Thane of Cawdor. I'll be free
To choose a new profession; giving up
The war I fight, which means I am no soldier.
I'm free to choose a country, for a Scotsman
Who flees from Scotland when its very being
Is threatened, is no Scot at all. Indeed,
No more am I a man, for what is he
That lets his life like coastal cliff erode
Collapsing slowly, imperceptibly,
Until the sea has swallowed all he was,
Save what survives within the memory
Of those he leaves behind him on the earth.
If I allow this stream to carry me
Away upon its current, I condemn
My legacy to ruin and, I fear,
My country to calamity. His reign
Will soon be blown from Scotland's sombre skies
If Duncan still insists on purging those
Who speak a truth he doesn't wish to hear,
And then to whom should Scotland look? To Malcolm?
He said himself his narrow shoulders ne'er
Could bear the weight of gold upon his head.
Then who? Macbeth? Or Ross? Some other thane
Who's crawled out from the dirt, like worms in rain,
And slithered into Duncan's fragile brain
To sit behind his glassy eyes, grown over
With cataracts of pride, a parasite
That slowly comes to dominate its host
And turn his body to its creeping will?
Though I could freely float along this river,
The pestilence which I would leave behind
Would still remain upstream and follow me
To where the current leads. But if I choose
To row, untiring, against the flow,
And travel up this artery toward
The heart of Scotland, then there is a chance

Let us now hear his love for honest Cawdor,
A man who runs and yet is innocent?
He flees to join his viking masters. Banquo:
As traitors in the shadows multiply
As bosom friends draw jealous knives by night,
We value higher now than e'er before
All those whose loyalty outranks their greed,
And we reward it here: Sons, kinsmen, thanes,
And you whose places are the nearest, know
The title of the Thane of Lochaber
Is given to our loyal servant, Banquo.
He reaps the harvest of his fealty.

BANQUO
Though oaths no longer seem to hold the weight
As once they did for other men, my own
Still keep me ballasted and firm.

Enter Lennox

DUNCAN
Lennox?
Where is my son?

LENNOX
He can't be found, my liege.
I fear that he has left to go with Cawdor.

DONALBAIN
With Cawdor?

LENNOX
Aye, he was the one who freed him.
He drugged the guards and let him loose.

DUNCAN
Malcolm?
I've pushed him into Cawdor's waiting arms.

ROSS
Sire, I know
This revelation throws our balance off
But we must now be steady on our feet.

The time is fast approaching when our options
Will be severely limited. Cawdor
Can furnish Sweno with intelligence
That could be mortal to our cause. Therefore,
We must not tarry further. Macduff,
You shared with me some information
Which I believe could help us. Tell the King.

MACDUFF

My liege, I have command of loyal fighters
Who, now encamped near where the enemy
Consolidates his force, could strike before
The Norse invaders can arrange themselves
And march upon this castle.
Though small in number, with a strategy
Of harassment and skirmishing I think
We could so chip away at -

DUNCAN

Leave me, now.

ROSS

My king, we must discuss what -

DUNCAN

I said leave me.

MACDUFF

We do not have the time to waste on woe.
For Cawdor rides to Sweno's side e'en now
And Malcolm likely with him, therefore, sire -

DUNCAN

Speak one more word and all the time you have
Will soon be wasted too.

ROSS

Macduff.

(Aside to Macduff)

You are too hot. The King is paralysed
For Malcolm's flight is like the adder's bite;
The venom spreading both to heart and brain.
I'm certain that the plan we have proposed

Aye.

For now, let's talk elsewhere, for look, he stares
And we should let him mourn his son's desertion.

Exit Banquo and Macbeth

DONALBAIN

There is an explanation for this, father.
You mustn't think that Malcolm -

DUNCAN

Donalbain.

DONALBAIN

These guards may well be lying.

DUNCAN

When I ordered
That Cawdor be imprisoned, did you speak?
Did you discuss my judgement with your brother?

DONALBAIN

I did.

DUNCAN

He thought me wrong to do it.

DONALBAIN

He was worried;
He did not wish to see you lose an ally.

DUNCAN

Well now I've lost an ally and a son.

DONALBAIN

There's more to this I'm sure of it.

DUNCAN

Be gone.

Exit Donalbain

What fools are kings to think their crowns divine
Empower them as gods who walk the Earth?

The power of a crown is in the minds
Of those who look upon it. It's a tale,
A story that we tell; A player's masque
For which we don our false, pretending garb,
To sing our songs and speak our studied lines,
To dance our jigs and pluck the lyre's string,
To charm our audience, making them believe
That what we conjure in their minds is real.
But if they ever realised that without
Their willing, dumb embrace of our pretence,
Our glitt'ring crowns would look like what they are:
Rare metal wrapped around a common head.
The candle wick, I fear, is growing short.
Unlike the player who is given his part,
I do not know how long my speech will last
And that a simple flourish of a quill
May shape the final word I am to say...
And yet, these sisters seem to see the script.
They've heard the play before and know its end,
But only show me smudged and spotted pages
From which I must piece out my own conclusion.
Must I accept that what will come will come?
That fate has been ordained and long-decided?
Or do they show me drafts of what could be,
Instructions for a route the tale might take,
The journey planned, but not yet set upon?
The parchment clear as cloudless sky, the ink
Still swirling in its little sable sea.
I won't become a prisoner of this script;
I'll wrest this pen from fate's resilient grip.

Exit Duncan

Act 3, Scene 5 - Eastern Scotland, Sweno's Camp

Sweno sits alone. He is wearing armour with a hole in the breastplate, just below the ribs.

Enter Harthacnut accompanied by a Norse Soldier.

SWENO

The Scotsman has returned, at last?

HARTHACNUT

Half-dead,
The living half is just outside the tent.

SWENO
He comes alone?

HARTHACNUT
Alone, but for his smell,
Which, it would seem, has been a staunch companion.

SWENO
Bring him before me, brother.

HARTHACNUT
Is that wise?

SWENO
You, bring him in.

Exit Norse Soldier

HARTHACNUT
We don't know -

SWENO
Brother, please,
Ne'er question me before the men again.

Enter Norse Soldier followed by Cawdor

CAWDOR
King Sweno.

SWENO
Cawdor. When were you last fed?

CAWDOR
Some days ago, I'd say.

SWENO
Fetch meat and ale.

Exit Norse Soldier

SWENO

When last we met, you were the picture of
A man who had been brushed by Death, but now
He has his hands around your throat. Does this,
Your slovenly aspect, reflect the view
King Duncan takes of my proposal?

CAWDOR

I told him of your offer, Sweno, but
The presence of his Thanes provoked his fear
That any weakness they perceived in him
Would trigger more rebellion in their ranks.
They saw no reason, only treachery
And so he sent me to the cells, 'mid calls
From many in the court, I have no doubt,
To fix my head upon a pike.

SWENO

And yet
You stand before us with your head attached.

CAWDOR

King Duncan's son, young Malcolm, came and freed me.
He knows I'd die for Scotland.

HARTHACNUT

As you might.

SWENO

I told you what would have to come to pass
If Duncan saw no sense.

CAWDOR

You did, indeed;
But then why would you tender peace at all?
Your fighters number in the tens of thousands,
Why make an offer such as this?

SWENO

I can
Rescind it if it doesn't please you?

CAWDOR

Why

Would Sweno, bold and bloody warrior-king,
Who leads his men in every fight, who sailed
Across the foaming sea to swell his rule,
Who never offers parley, never falters,
Come forward now with plans for peace?

HARTHACNUT

Hark, Scotsman,
That tongue has not long left inside your head
If you continue wagging it about.

CAWDOR

Harth-a-kuh-noot - is that how it's pronounced?
Your brother nearly killed me when we fought,
He had me in the mud, I was disarmed,
But ere he split my head in two, a pike
Was thrust into his chest, he bears the mark -
At least his armour does, if not his trunk.
Twas you who bore his body, I believe,
Before the horns then called your soldiers back.
He should be dead.

SWENO

And yet, you see, I live.

CAWDOR

Miraculous, considering the pike
Was wielded by a Highland Warrior
Who, as is customary, would have used
A poison made from wolfsbane to ensure
That any wounded by his pike would die
Within a day. And yet, I see, you live.

Enter Norse Soldier with food and drink.

CAWDOR

I think that that's for me.

SWENO

Leave it and go.

Exit Norse Soldier

CAWDOR

Your army is the largest I have seen.
I've never known a force so vast, it must
Be held together in such subtle balance;
The weight so perfectly distributed,
The slightest change would cause the scales to tip.

SWENO

You are a shrewd one, Thane of Cawdor, aye.

Sweno removes their armour and helmet revealing wrapping underneath and that they are in fact a woman: Gunhilda.

GUNHILDA

My brother Sweno's dead. I am Gunhilda.
I shared my mother's womb with Sweno, now
I take his name and with it, leadership
Of all the drengir fighting in this land.

HARTHACNUT

I'd had a mind to kill you, Scotsman, now
It is decided.

GUNHILDA

Brother, stay your blade.

CAWDOR

You wear King Sweno's mantle?

GUNHILDA

Aye.

CAWDOR

And hide

Your womanhood from twenty-thousand men,
But why this ruse?
Is Sweno's living brother not his heir?
Or does he lack the necessary charm?
I've struck upon a nerve.

GUNHILDA

The scales you speak of,

Our brother Sweno did not balance them,
He was the fulcrum which they rested on.
King Sweno was a fierce, fearless fighter.

They called him Sweno the Indomitable,
For every fight he fought, he won unwounded.
The stories spread, transforming into myth,
Rewarding risk and recklessness, until
The clans of Norway bowed to him alone.
We begged him to remember he was made
Of fragile flesh, but even he began
Believing in the legends and the songs
That claimed he could not be our brother but
The son of Thor himself. Harthacnut,
Great warrior and leader though he is,
Could never take his place for that would mean
Th'indominatable Sweno ne'er was thus.

CAWDOR
And yet Gunhilda has.

GUNHILDA
 Gunhilda is no more.
Believing that her brother's wound was fatal,
Her faith in his immortal being shaken,
Gunhilda took her life in tragic error.
We burned her body yesterday.

CAWDOR
Your men believed this tale?

GUNHILDA
 They did.

CAWDOR
 The one,
Who ventured out alone across the field
Unarmed, to offer peace, that wasn't Sweno.

GUNHILDA
T'was I.

CAWDOR
 You've courage, lady.

GUNHILDA
 Spare me, Scotsman.

CAWDOR

So, when your twenty-thousand men discover
That you've made twenty-thousand fools of them
How dreadful will their retribution be?

GUNHILDA

I share my brother's face and now his crown -
I do not share his arrogance. I know
The sun already sets on my imposture.
This war must end before the truth is known
In such a way that satisfies my men.
We will not conquer Scotland but we must
Have land to call our own from this campaign.
And so I sought to end it, not with brawn
But brain. Alas, it seems your once wise Duncan
Has made the opposite exchange and so
Has forced my hand.

CAWDOR

Although you have the men,
You do not have the time. For Duncan can
Survive a lengthy siege and you will find
He's not your only enemy, the rebels
I told you of before now stand united
Behind a man whose brutish savagery
Is matched by only his ambition
And thirst for vengeance. He is called Macdonwald.
Both you and Duncan now are under threat
From those in his command. This saying nothing
Of all the burning woe he would unleash
Upon the common people of this land.
However, I can see a winding route
Which leads us both to what we want.

GUNHILDA

Which is?

CAWDOR

You offer an alliance to Macdonwald.
You promise him the throne, and in exchange
His forces form the vanguard of attack.
You send him out ahead and let his army
So grate against King Duncan's until both
Are left but bloody stumps of what they were.

Your Norsemen then can turn upon the rebels
And cauterise the wound, this being done,
I go to Duncan, tell him - peacefully -
To pass the throne to one who will reward
The service Norway has provided by
Extinguishing this rebel threat. The men
You need to please will then receive their lands
And we between us will have carved a future
Where Norse and Scot can live in friendly peace.

GUNHILDA

You turn so freely 'gainst your King?

CAWDOR

Duncan

Is paralysed by panic and advised
By those who leverage panic into power.
The man I served for all my life is gone,
Replaced by one who is not fit to rule.

GUNHILDA

He has no heirs?

CAWDOR

Not one who'd turn against him,
For both of Duncan's sons adore their father.

HARTHACNUT

You said it was his son who freed you.

CAWDOR

Yes,

Attempting to undo his father's error,
And save a wise advisor. For, if Malcolm
Was driven by ambition he would hold
A deep desire to see me dead. He knows
I'm seen as a potential heir and said,
Mere days ago, he hoped I would be named;
The thought of power scares him.

GUNHILDA

Well, what of

Macdonwald, he's not scared of power, is he?
He's proved he can command these flighty rebels,

So why not all of Scotland?

CAWDOR

Let us say

You chose to lift him up by the scruff o'the neck
And place him neatly down on Scotland's throne.
As soon as you had turned your back to leave
The snarling cur would pounce.

HARTHACNUT

This is the one

Whose men you plan to sacrifice. You think
A man so faithless won't suspect such schemes?

CAWDOR

Ambition fogs a foolish mind.

HARTHACNUT

And there,

At least, we're in agreement.

GUNHILDA

So it seems

We have exhausted every choice. Unless
A future King of Scotland stands before us?

CAWDOR

I am the Thane of Cawdor. I have served
The Scottish people all my life. I hold
More territory within their hearts than Duncan,
His sons, the rebels, and his thanes combined.
It's long been spoken of in court that he
Could name me as his heir, and there's no other
Who'd have the means and opportunity
To help you keep your brother's final promise.

Gunhilda replaces her armour.

GUNHILDA

I am the daughter of Cnut the Great,
Who once ruled over three illustrious kingdoms.
Granddaughter of the fearsome Sweno Forkbeard,
The first marauding Danish King of England.
I'm great-granddaughter to The Bluetooth who

United all the tribes of warring Danes
And held their leashes in his armoured hand.

CAWDOR
You come from mighty stock.

GUNHILDA
You would do well,
To keep that mighty stock fresh in your mind
Ere you consider that same treachery
That you have wrought upon King Duncan. Men!

Enter Norse Soldiers.

GUNHILDA
This Scot will need some lodging. Tell my envoys
I wish to send a message to one called
Macdonwald, leader of the Scottish rebels.
And as for you, Cawdor, we'll speak anon.

Exit Cawdor with Norse Soldiers.

HARTHACNUT
We cannot trust him.

GUNHILDA
Not quite yet, perhaps.

HARTHACNUT
You send him out amongst our soldiers, armed
With knowledge that could kill us both.

GUNHILDA
Oh yes,
A ragged Scotsman prancing through the camp:
'Gunhilda lives! She wears her brother's britches'
I think we need not fret.

HARTHACNUT
He saunters in
And has you crown him King within a breath.
We do not know this land, its laws and customs,
Nor do we know this man; an enemy
Should not so thoughtlessly be made a friend.

GUNHILDA

Nor is he, brother. Trust in me, I pray.
I do not slide my neck into the noose
But study how the rope can be of use.

Exeunt

Interval

Act 4, Scene 1 - Macdonwald's tent in the rebel camp, near Fife

Enter Cawdor and Macdonwald

CAWDOR

Wherefore, Macdonwald, have you called me here?
What is your latest grievance?

MACDONWALD

In good time.
I've asked our Viking friends to join us too.

CAWDOR

I'll wait outside.

MACDONWALD

Come Cawdor, none of that,
This gives us time to talk! How go the wars?
I hear you did not even unsheathe your sword
When we set out to take Dunbarney town.
No men cut down, no blood drawn, not a mark
Was made on your bright armour. No, instead
They say you were negotiating peace,
A truce to open up their rotting gates
And let us in without a blow exchanged.
Your reputation as a warlike captain
Preceded you but now it drags behind.
The truth, which all the tales omit, is that,
Just like a pale and squeamish chambermaid,
You'd faint if you but pricked your sewing finger.

CAWDOR

You think we should have burned their houses down?
Beheaded all the men, and ta'en the women
And spitted all the infants on our pikes?

MACDONWALD

Why do you fear to spill the blood of those
Whose loyalty is Duncan's, still? I thought
His lap no longer warmed your quiv'ring haunch.
Perhaps you only play the rebel's part
And Duncan's fist still grips your pallid heart.

CAWDOR

What madness do you mumble now?

MACDONWALD

Oh, yes,

You call me mad, you thanes of here and there,
You tell your stories of me in your halls,
But he that made me mad is that same king
To whom you bow and simper. If you knew
The things that Duncan's done, your sickly stomach,
Would purge the rancid meat he deigned to throw
To keep you fed and tame, and even then
The burning in your throat from heaving up
That caustic bile would bring to mind the knowledge
Whenever you sat down to feed again.
There was a time when I was Thane of Cawdor.
I once sat proud at Duncan's side, like you.
Like you, he took me in when I was young
And like you too, he made a tool of me.
Unlike the careful smith who will repair
A loosened hammerhead, King Duncan cast
This tool he broke aside. He did so then,
He's done so now to you and I would wager
The Cawdor after you will have the same.

CAWDOR

You murdered children. You were sent to end
A minor mutiny, instead you burned
And butchered with impunity. You claim
That you were 'cast aside'? He let you live;
So brash an act of generosity
It bordered on the foolish.

MACDONWALD

Generous?

He did not spare my life, he stretchèd out
The torture I'd endure before my death.
You think it mercy to condemn a man
To live with scorpions inside his mind?
'Twas guilt that cowed the King from killing me.

CAWDOR

What guilt has Duncan for that massacre?

MACDONWALD

Come, Cawdor, you know just as well as I:
A good dog acts upon his master's word.

Enter Gunhilda (as Sweno) and Harthacnut

GUNHILDA

Macdonwald, you have summoned us, we've come.
What is it you'd discuss?

HARTHACNUT

The hour's late.

MACDONWALD

I have your ears at last my frosty friends,
Now, let me tell you why I summon you.
My numbers dwindle, I have lost a third
Of those that crossed the Sea of Hebrides
To aid me in the tyrant's deposition.

HARTHACNUT

That is the cost of war.

MACDONWALD

And one that falls
Most heavily on me. We share a feast,
But when the bill is paid, it is my purse
That's left the lightest, while, across the table
Your brother, here, coughs up a coin or two
And Cawdor's guts are fattened up for free.

GUNHILDA

The feast is not shared equally, you'll have
The lion's share - you will be Scotland's King.
You said your fighters were the best and so
They lead the line.

MACDONWALD

But you have used my men
For fodder, while you shiver safe behind
Their wall of flesh.

CAWDOR

No discipline.

MACDONWALD

What's that?

CAWDOR

No order, no routine, no regimen;
You men lack discipline and so do you.

MACDONWALD

They are the fiercest fighters in this horde,
The warriors of the Western Isles' lives
Are spent in constant battle for survival
Upon those blasted rocks they call their home.
And who did rally them into an army?
Who fused these warring bands all into one?
'Twas I, with spine of steel and heart of granite;
These men would follow no one else but me.

CAWDOR

They barely follow you, they blunder forward,
Unregimented, swiping madly forth
Like drunken bears. These men, they are no soldiers.
They're brutes and criminals, oath-breaking villains.
Thus far, they've had the honour of the vanguard,
What glory could be won your men have ta'en,
But now it seems Macdonwald cannot bear
The weight of honour any further.

MACDONWALD

What?

CAWDOR

You've cost yourself too many soldiers' lives
And now you want another to take charge.

MACDONWALD

And who should lead the vanguard, Cawdor, you?
The tortoise, plodding forward, ever slow-
Except to hide inside his rigid shell.

CAWDOR

The tortoise lives a hundred years, unlike
The mayflies that you make of all your men.

For, if I led, then we would not be doomed
To break upon the castle of King Duncan
As though we were a wave against a cliff.

MACDONWALD

You wish to be the one to lead this army?
You think you are the better soldier?

CAWDOR

From what I've seen I'm yet to be convinced
You could contend with me in any way.

MACDONWALD

In any way? You whelp, I'll have your heart
From out your ribs, and feed it to you, beating.
I'll let my lions off their leash and you
Will know the bloody ruin they can wreak.
Their rage will rip through bone and flesh and armour,
Their claws will ravage Scot and Norseman, both.

GUNHILDA

Macdonwald leads the line, that is my word.
He will make march on Forres first, while we
Will follow and then lend our steel to him.
The casting vote is mine.

MACDONWALD

Is that relief
I see in Cawdor's eyes? He may yet see
The end of this campaign without the need
To clean a single spot from his soft hands.
Now, Sweno, tell me how you will assuage
The losses I have suffered, pray?

GUNHILDA

Macdonwald,
Be sure that I have heard you. We will lend
Some men to fill the spaces in your ranks.
Will you consent to have my brother follow
And guard your flank while you lead from the front?

MACDONWALD

You'll follow orders?

GUNHILDA

Aye, he will.

MACDONWALD

I'd like

To hear the words from him.

GUNHILDA

Harthacnut.

MACDONWALD

Your king is speaking to you, sirrah.

You'll follow orders?

GUNHILDA

Brother.

HARTHACNUT

Yes.

MACDONWALD

Good boy.

Then tag along, and maybe I will teach
You how to war. For now, I must escape
The stinking musk of Cawdor's sweet perfume.
I'll tell my fighters they will be the first
Through Duncan's splintered gates, save only me
Who will be leading them in bloody charge.
Now follow, Viking.

GUNHILDA

I must bless my brother
Before he leaves for battle, 'tis our custom.

MACDONWALD

Well, keep the blather brief, we've miles to march.

Exit Macdonwald

HARTHACNUT

So now I serve the madman?

GUNHILDA

Brother -

HARTHACNUT

No.

This time you overstep the mark, Gunhilda.
You may wear Sweno's armour and his crown,
But you are not my king, and I am not
Your subject to be ordered here and there.

GUNHILDA

Nor do I think of you as such.

HARTHACNUT

Don't lie,

I see the glee with which you play this part.

GUNHILDA

Then go, proclaim the truth to all our host:
That Sweno's in Valhalla and his sister
Has climbed inside his empty shell. Then watch
As one hand tears the fingers from the other,
As men from rival holds give in to slaughter
Held off for fabled son but not for daughter.
She will, of course, endure a cruelty
Impossible for men to fathom 'til
They find themselves inflicting it. And then
They'll scatter in this foreign land to raid,
And rape and burn, eventually to perish,
Surrounded, brotherless, never to look
On Norway's spotless snows ever again.
Since Sweno died, my hand has only sought
An oar to row me back to Norway' shores
With you and all our countrymen aboard.

HARTHACNUT

Macdonwald is no fool, he guessed your plan;
He knows you use him as a shield.

CAWDOR

And yet,

He let the glint of pride distract his gaze.
The castle's siege will prove too tedious;
Temptation for assault will overwhelm him
And so will prove his ruin. Let his men
Wear down Duncan's defences, our full host

Will so o'erwhelm his own when it arrives
That he will have no choice but to surrender.

HARTHACNUT
Those lands had best be ours when this is done.

GUNHILDA
They will be. Odin's eye upon you.

HARTHACNUT
Farewell.

Exit Harthacnut

GUNHILDA
I've lost one brother to this war already,
And fear I might have just forgone another.

CAWDOR
This plan will work.

GUNHILDA
Macdonwald doesn't trust you,
But you have learnt to play him like a harp.
His strings were in suspicion's tuning, but
You deftly worked him into prideful rage,
And strummed a melody so well performed,
The harmony could well be played on me.
An instrument more challenging perhaps
And, may I say, requiring hands more deft,
But I doubt not that you could, practised, prove
A more than worthy master of its strings,
And play us both in dulcet symphony.

CAWDOR
My lady -

GUNHILDA
I am no one's lady, Cawdor.

CAWDOR
But you are the superior musician,
I'm but a lonely troubadour, compared.
Each harp of heartstrings in your soldiers' chests

At once, sing out your composition.
Besides, I did not play this tune alone;
I may have played the right hand but the left
Was all your own. My cunning might concern you,
Imagine what your guile inspires in me.

GUNHILDA

It's rare to have my prowess fairly judged;
My greatest ally, disregard, is slain.

CAWDOR

I would have been a fool to let it live.
You bear a weight, Gunhilda.

GUNHILDA

One heavier
Than any King of Norway's ever known.
How many lives can occupy one body?
Mine bears the leaden load of double-life.
I'm glad I am a woman, for a man
Would not have strength to hold the weight of both;
Your bodies are not made with room to hold
The spirit of another but my mother
Bore hers, my brother Sweno's and my own.
He came into the world with me and now
I cannot let him go and though I wish
To grant him rest, his soul I have arrested.
I puppet him, I think his thoughts, I speak
The words I'd have him say and so he lives
A shadow life, a demi-death. The Valkyries,
Can see his soul inside my heart, they reach
Between my ribs to steal it back from me
To bring it to Valhalla, as they must,
But jealously, I cage it in my chest
And mask my face with his. I long for when
My brother Sweno can be truly dead;
Gunhilda then can live, herself, again.

CAWDOR

I wish it too.

GUNHILDA

The poison which you spoke of,
That tipped that pike which pierced his mortal chest,

What pain would it have caused him as he died?

CAWDOR

Forgive me, for in truth, there's no such thing.
I merely wished to test my strange suspicion,
That all with Sweno was not as it seemed.
In my defence, it worked.

GUNHILDA

A move well made.
You've long been playing tunes to me, it seems.

CAWDOR

If I have bred disturbed imaginings
Of how your brother spent his final moments,
Know this: from what I saw, his death was sharp
And quick, befitting of a warrior.
I ask for your forgiveness.

GUNHILDA

I am grateful
To know the soul I carry made its way
From Sweno's body to my own without
Great suffering and pain. Goodnight.

CAWDOR

Goodnight.

Exit Gunhilda

How close together life and death can be,
Contained within a single trunk is he
Who wished to pinch my flickering wick of life
And snuff it out forever, next to him
Is she whose whisper bellows at the flame,
Her breath inspiring jealous gluttony,
Which threatens to engulf me lest I beat
The grasping fire back.

Enter a Rebel Soldier, with a sword drawn. Cawdor draws his sword.

CAWDOR

You wear Macdonwald's colours, tell me why
You burst into his tent, blade drawn?

Perhaps he cut your tongue away and keeps
It somewhere in his lodging? If you want
I'll help you search.
Speak soldier, what's the matter?

REBEL SOLDIER

I thought that I heard someone in here, sir.
We lost a scout today and so I thought
There might be one here armoured in our garb
Who holds a dagger for us in his heart.

CAWDOR

You did not hear the whispers of a spy
Instead, the musings of a tired general.
I'll warn Macdonwald of this threat. Stay here
And guard the entrance to his tent.

REBEL SOLDIER

Aye, sir.

Exit Cawdor

The Rebel Soldier removes his helmet, it is Malcolm

MALCOLM

We are the stories that we tell and make
The truth we wish to live, and so he does
Because I struck his name from Hades' list,
My father saw the man he was and I
Released him from his rightful bonds. The hate
My heart now harbours threatens to invade
And spread its fires to my mind but I
Must halt it's fevered rampage if I hope
To make amends for this most foolish error.
I came to take Macdonwald's head, I must
Not let this quarry draw my eye from that
Which I have journeyed here to hunt.
Macdonwald, must fall first and then the rest,
For, with his death, so will rebellion die.
Macdonwald, Sweno, Cawdor, that's the way.
With blade and flame, as Heracles once did,
I'll cut and cauterise the Hydra's heads:
Beginning with the Rebel, then the Viking
And finally the Traitor; him, I'll save

And savour my repayment of his lessons.
For now, I'll hide among Macdonwald's host
And when the chance to strike presents itself,
I'll cut the stomach from this reaving beast
And save my country from his fetid feast.

Exit Malcolm

Act 4, Scene 2 - Court of King Duncan, Forres

Enter Duncan, Donalbain, Macbeth and Banquo

DUNCAN

How many thankless birds have taken wing
Migrating forth to Cawdor's meagre nest?

BANQUO

We have reports that Cawdor still enjoys
The loyalty of all those he commanded
In his campaign to hold the Eastern lands.
They, too, have turned against us.
Reports that they have allied with Macdonwald
Are now confirmed. The three combined forces,
Of Cawdor, Sweno and Macdonwald all
Consolidate their power in the East,
And soon will march on Forres, there's no doubt.

MACBETH

You still have many fighting men, my king,
And now you can be sure their loyalty
Is not as quickly bent as that of those
Who heed the calling horns of foul rebellion.
One loyal fighter's worth a hundred doubters
Especially when besieged. The fewer men,
The fewer mouths to feed.

BANQUO

We have supplied,
And may outlast a siege of many months.
Our stocks will last far longer than this truce.
When battle's bonds are slackened in a siege,
Their boredom and frustration soon will fester,
And traitors once, will traitors be again.

DUNCAN

And is there word of Malcolm?

BANQUO

None, my lord.

Enter a Doctor with a vial

DUNCAN

Macbeth and Banquo, thank you. Leave me now.

Exit Macbeth and Banquo

DUNCAN

What do you bring me, Doctor?

DOCTOR

Good even, sire.

This tincture should envelop you in calm
And slow those running thoughts that mar your rest.
Take three drops and no more of this my liege,
An hour before you sleep with food and water.

DUNCAN

And if it doesn't work?

DOCTOR

If one hour passes
And still you cannot sleep, take one more drop -
Again, dissolved in water, but no more;
I warn you sire, this is a potent drug
And too much taken or not ta'en with care,
Particularly for a man your age,
May cause a deeper slumber than we'd like.

DUNCAN

The prospect serves as less of a deterrent
Than you may think, good Doctor.

DOCTOR

I assume

Your majesty is -

DONALBAIN

Aye, he speaks in jest.

DOCTOR

And are there any other matters, sire,
With which I may assist?

DUNCAN

Nothing. Unless
There is another tincture you'd prescribe
To calm a body larger than my own;
To cool its boiling lochs and quell its thunder
And prove an antidote for rage and fear?

DOCTOR

Despite my learning, sire, of we two;
I'd say that your vocation has more scope
To diagnose and treat such an affliction.
I'm sure the cure will soon be found, my liege.
I hope you sleep well, sire.

DUNCAN

Thank you, Doctor.

Exit Doctor

DONALBAIN

Shall I prepare your sleeping draught?

DUNCAN

No, boy.
I'm not yet old and feeble, we have time
Before our roles reverse and you become
A parent to your parent.

DONALBAIN

I did not think you were unable, father.
When did you last sleep through the night?

DUNCAN

I was your age, it was the night before
They named me Prince of Cumberland. That weight
Has never left my mind since then.

DONALBAIN

I wonder,
If sharing out this weight may give relief?

DUNCAN

You wish to lend your father strength, my son?
Then let us see what weight your back can bear:
I am beset, embattled on all sides.
The rebels and the Norsemen march in step,
My son and closest ally plot my doom,
The friends I thought I had begin to fade
As if their forms to smoke are turned straight
Just as I go to lean on them, for Ross
Has left my side as well as young Macduff.
No sooner is the hawk's hood taken off,
But flies it from me. Enemies divided
Are now united, marching on this castle
And we have days before we are besieged.

DONALBAIN

Our captains claim these walls will hold them back,
And that the enemy encampment will
Descend into undisciplined disorder.

DUNCAN

You've never known a siege, my blessed boy.
You've never had plague-ridden bodies hurled
Over your walls. You've never had to watch
Your starving soldiers turn from men to beasts
And scrap among themselves like feral cubs.
You've never heard the screaming of your people,
The peasants with no walls to keep them safe,
Their cursed choir quavering day and night
Beyond the bulwark that you hide behind,
Or heard them plead with you and curse your name
While knowing you could end their suffering
By simply opening the gates. You hope,
Disorder will destroy our enemies?
The spread of that disease is wide and deep;
Th'infection incubates inside these walls
And soon we'll feel the fever taking hold.

DONALBAIN

I trust your strength won't fail you, father, now.

Just as I trust this tincture will provide
The means for rest and restoration.

DUNCAN
I'll take it, straight.

DONALBAIN
Good night.

DUNCAN
Good night, my boy.

Exit Donalbain

DUNCAN
Simplicity of youth to think that sleep
Could wrest us from disaster's clawing grip.

Enter The Sisters

I hear the fateful sisters' words, anew,
Reverberating round my aching skull:

THE SISTERS
A single foe will form from two
And when they have encircled you
The only son of bold Macbeth
Will bring you victory in death.
So look to him, when all seems lost
But know that you will pay the cost.

DUNCAN
I hear the fatal footsteps of a thought,
Which echo down an empty corridor
Outside the room all thoughts set out to enter,
A room I cower inside, my breathing silent,
The door of which I press my weight against
Refusing entry, pulling bolts across
In desperate attempt to keep it out.
But now a knocking makes the hinges rattle
Demanding that this thought be welcomed in,
The wooden door is creaking, splintering
And lest I let myself be crushed, I must
Surrender and allow this thought to enter;

The only son of bold Macbeth
Will bring you victory in death.
How could this bring me victory, but then
These Sisters seem to see the rippling waves
Before the stone is thrown into the depths.
And if I fail to act, what happens then?
If I refuse to grasp the line thrown out
I will be pulled below the rapid water
And with me, all my subjects sheltering here.
Macdonwald will not take a single hostage;
Expecting mercy from a predator
Is folly that the prey cannot afford.
It could be said this act was merciful
Exchanging my own purity of soul
To spare a poor, defenceless, helpless infant
From suffering a cruel and awful end,
Which, sure, would be the doom that would befall him.
His mother said the baby was unwell.
A sickly child rarely 'scapes the fate
Of suffering an aching, creeping death,
The agony prolonged for child and parent.
I offer an escape, an act of kindness
Which done, would save my land from untold horror
And save the child from his suffering.
I have the very thing, it would be painless.
This is the sacrifice the sisters said
Would find out victory in the mist of dread.
The hurt that's done does not outweigh the good.
I do a deed I never thought I could.

Exeunt

Act 4, Scene 3 - Near Forres

Enter Harthacnut and Macdonwald

MACDONWALD

I know Norweyan nerves begin to jitter
When you have tramped upon the land too long.
You miss your little boats with dragon heads?

HARTHACNUT

We fight as well on land as on the sea.

MACDONWALD

I cannot wait to see it. We're one league
Away from Duncan's stronghold and tomorrow
The walls will tumble down before my power.

HARTHACNUT

Tomorrow we'll begin the siege, Macdonwald.
It may be many months before we see
The inside of those walls, we will need patience.
I'll go and tell my men to set up camp.

Exit Harthacnut

MACDONWALD

O fear not, Viking, for Macdonwald has
More patience than you know.

Enter Malcolm behind him with a sword drawn.

Already now,
My life has stretched on longer than it should.

MALCOLM

Then I will end it for you.

MACDONWALD

Who is this?

MALCOLM

My name is Malcolm.

MACDONWALD

So, the old bull sends
His gangling calf to hunt the hungry wolf?
He throws away his sons so easily.

MALCOLM

Macdonwald, I have come to take the head
My father should have never let you keep,
And so avenge those murdered innocents
Who, by your hand, were massacred.

MACDONWALD

Ah yes.

You think you know your father, boy?

MALCOLM

I know

I do not share his generosity.

MACDONWALD

He took me in, he raised me from a pup
And trained me to obey his sharp commands.
He generously sent me to that place
To where those sharp-set sons of soil stood,
Their scythes and pitchforks, nought but scaffolding
To hold their broken bodies up. They begged
Reprieve from starving, taxing toil. Duncan
Had told me to be generous, indeed;
With orders not to leave that wasted place
'Til their revolt was ground beneath my boot -
To make example of them, lest a plague
Of wilfulness was spread across our lands.
He generously made me a degenerate;
The stink of burning flesh forever clings
Behind my nose, the taste of bloody vapour
Forever settled on my tongue. I did
What Duncan bade me do and in return
He failed to send my soul to hell, instead
He made me live with hell inside my head.

MALCOLM

You lie.

MACDONWALD

I wish I did, but worry not:
His generosity will be returned,
And soon his crown will gild my waiting brow.

MALCOLM

You'll wear no crown without your head, you cur!

They fight. Macdonwald pins Malcolm to the ground.

Enter Harthacnut with Soldiers

MACDONWALD

Farewell young Malcolm, son of Duncan. You,
At least, have tried for valour.

He goes to strike a fatal blow.

HARTHACNUT

Hold your blade!

This is King Duncan's eldest son?

MACDONWALD

For now.

HARTHACNUT

Why would you kill him, fool?

MACDONWALD

You watch your tongue,

Or I will have it from you, Viking dog.

HARTHACNUT

Hold yours until your brain has matched its pace.

The enemy delivers us a prize,

The perfect merchandise to bargain with.

His life could buy us entry to the keep.

MALCOLM

I'd rather die.

MACDONWALD

Well, by your leave.

HARTHACNUT

Hold off!

This boy is far more use to us alive.

If I am wrong, the pleasure of his death

I'll leave to you alone.

MACDONWALD

I'll stay my blade for now but only so

Anticipation, with delay, can grow.

Malcolm is bound.

There is your precious hostage, Viking. But

If you defy my will again -

HARTHACNUT

You'll what?

My axe is parched and desperate to quench
Its yearning thirst for blood.

MACDONWALD

Perhaps I'll offer

Its master's Viking ichor unto it
And show it how a weapon should be fed.

Exit Macdonwald

MALCOLM

You seem to get along.

HARTHACNUT

If I were you,

I wouldn't waste my words, except to pray.

MALCOLM

He vowed to purge your Viking scourge and built
His gang of rebels from those very men
Who cursed the King for failing to repel
Your raiding parties. Yet, against all logic,
He marches next to you. His choice of friends.
Is curious, indeed. You shouldn't trust him.

HARTHACNUT

I need not hold you from Macdonwald's jaws,
With every word you speak I reconsider
If I should not allow the dog its toy.

MALCOLM

Before your battle's won that rabid dog
Will turn upon the one who holds his leash.
Where is King Sweno, by the way? I thought
He fought among his soldiers or is that
A story that you tell?

HARTHACNUT

Take him away.

Exit Malcolm, escorted by Norse Soldiers

Act 4, Scene 4 - Castle Forres

Enter Banquo and a Sergeant

BANQUO

How many men and how far from us, Sergeant?

SERGEANT

Not far, Lord Banquo, but one league away.
We guess their siege will fall on us by sunrise.
We see Macdonwald's banner and another
Not Scot, but Norse.

BANQUO

King Sweno?

SERGEANT

No, my lord.

I fought against the Norse King in the East.
These are his brother's colours.

BANQUO

What of Cawdor?

SERGEANT

We see no sign of him. It's strange, the host
I saw in Fife was twenty-thousand strong
It stretched to the horizon, but this army
Is less than half that size and that includes
Macdonwald's Western Kerns.

BANQUO

'Tis curious.

We need more information, take some men,
No more than eight, and keep them out of sight.
Approach this Rebel Viking camp and try
To understand the situation.

SERGEANT

Sir.

Exit Sergeant. Enter Macbeth

MACBETH
What news?

BANQUO
The force beyond the castle walls
Is smaller than what was believed. I've sent
A scouting party forth to find out more.

MACBETH
Good news.

BANQUO
But still, the situation's dire.
This is no place for wives and children.

MACBETH
Aye.
My wife is leaving now for Dunsinane,
I'm here to see them off.

A cry, within.

MACBETH
What is that noise?

BANQUO
It was a woman's cry.

Enter Lady Macbeth, holding the baby's body.

MACBETH
My wife, why do you stare?

BANQUO
Oh God.

MACBETH
Is that...?
Was that your cry that pierced my heart? You hold,
You hold...

BANQUO

We must send for a doctor.

LADY MACBETH

No.

No surgeon, nor no doctor, nor no God
Could stitch the gaping chasm in my chest.
I went to rouse him, he hadn't cried all morning.
He slept so soundly, looked so like an angel.
You spirits, you who play with mortal fates,
What have I done but love and cherish him?

Enter Duncan

DUNCAN

What fear brings forth such cries of woe and panic?
My lady, are you hurt?

BANQUO

The baby's sick.

I'll go and fetch the doctor.

Exit Banquo

DUNCAN

What is wrong?

I see the broken heart within your chest,
Your child is beyond a doctor's help.
I can't find words to name the desolation
I feel on your behalf. No parent ever,
You least of all, should have to feel such pain.
You both have hurt so much and had such little,
Such precious little time to sun yourselves
To bask in the glow, the radiance, your child
Had brought into your lives. And now the night
Has come so suddenly, straight after dawn.
I've never known a day so bright and short.
I have no words of comfort

LADY MACBETH

You did.

You said he'd die in battle, not in crib.

Enter Doctor and Banquo

DOCTOR
Where is the child?

BANQUO
Here. Come, let the doctor -

LADY MACBETH
I will not let him go, no, get away!
I'll feel what warmth is left in him, I must,
Until it's gone forever. After this,
I'll never know the heat of life again.

DOCTOR
What shall I do, my lord?

LADY MACBETH
Don't look at them.
They've never felt another beating heart
Tap out a rhythm in their swelling belly.
They've never felt the glowing hum cut short
When life in life is snuffed before its time.

DOCTOR
Forgive me, lady, may I check to see
In case there's something in my meagre power
That might be done for him? Is that all right?

The Doctor checks the baby's body.

DOCTOR
It's as I feared.

LADY MACBETH
It's as I knew.

BANQUO
Oh God.

DUNCAN
Is there no way to know, good doctor, what
Has caused this tragedy?

DOCTOR
No sign, my liege,

As far as brief inspection might reveal.
I know the child was not in perfect health,
Whate'er the cause might be, it was not dearth
Of love and care that brought this fate upon him.

BANQUO
Macbeth?

DUNCAN
It's like a freezing wind has fixed
His body and his soul in place.

BANQUO
Macbeth? Come, man, your wife needs your assistance.

MACBETH
I don't -

BANQUO
She needs you now, your woe must wait.
Come sire, we should leave them here to mourn.
Their time for grief is brief, our enemies
Will not stave off their battle plans for sorrow.
My liege, we have defences to prepare.
There is a passage out of here, my king,
A corridor through which you could escape
If Forres were to fall.

DUNCAN
The 'Coward's Tunnel'.

BANQUO
As long as you are free, my liege, Macdonwald
Can never truly claim the throne as his.
I've told the Thane of Lennox of this plan,
And if our keep proves pregnable he will
Escort you through the passageway to safety.

DUNCAN
Am I a good man, Banquo?

BANQUO
Sire, you are
The finest king that Scotland's ever known.

DUNCAN

I wonder how a man can ever know,
When actions taken ripple out through time
Resulting in events beyond his death.

BANQUO

We'll ponder on it once this battle's won.

Exit Banquo, Duncan and the Doctor

MACBETH

He's smaller than he was before.

Alarum

You must be gone to Dunsinane at once.

LADY MACBETH

The King, he told me something curious.
We spoke some nights ago, the boy was sick -
And Duncan tried to give me comfort; said
That he'd been told our son would die to win
A battle for the realm. And now our son -

MACBETH

The enemy is spotted, and his jaws -

LADY MACBETH

I swore I saw a glint of guilt or fear -

MACBETH

Close fast about us -

LADY MACBETH

In Duncan's twisted face -

MACBETH

You must slip between -

LADY MACBETH

But listen, husband -

MACBETH

His sharpened teeth before they shut up tight.

LADY MACBETH

Did you not see?

MACBETH

When?

LADY MACBETH

Now.

MACBETH

As he looked on you?

LADY MACBETH

Aye.

Alarum

MACBETH

Hark.

You must begone, I will not let this day

Take any more from me, the enemy

Is at our gates.

LADY MACBETH

But, listen, Duncan -

MACBETH

Now.

LADY MACBETH

Hark, husband, I could swear the King -

MACBETH

No more!

I will not hear this.

LADY MACBETH

Listen!

MACBETH

There's no time.

Begone to Dunsinane, begone at once.

I'll get my armour on, you must go hence.
Be safe there, I will see you when it's done.
Look out for letters from me.

LADY MACBETH

Get your armour on?
You'll make an aegis of your blood and bones
To guard this king who has already used
Your flesh to save himself? The stink of guilt
Has lingered after him like tallow's smog.
That smell will permeate and stick on you
If you refuse to hear me -

MACBETH

Wife, I beg you,
Our grief is fresh, the wound is yet to bleed;
If you were ripped from me as well I know,
It would condemn my soul to ruin. Now,
On bended knee, I beg you fly from here
Before Macdonwald's savagery arrives.
Begone. I'll send you letters.

LADY MACBETH

And our boy?
I'll bury him alone?

Alarum

MACBETH

There is no time.

LADY MACBETH

My husband, if you dare
To perish in this fight, I'll straight to Hell -
For that is where you'll be if you allow
Yourself to die in Duncan's servitude -
And will not rest until I find your soul
And wreak upon it such a dreadful vengeance
The devil himself will scream in fearful pity.

MACBETH

He'll be too busy with the sorry souls
That I'll be sending down to him, anon.

Exit Macbeth

LADY MACBETH

O, up and down and up and down and up
And down and up. His little ears are deaf.
O spirits of the darkness, hear me now:
The time will come when I will call upon you.
If, unrevengèd, in my grave I lie,
My soul, I will bequeath you when I die.

Exeunt

Act 5, Scene 1 - Lowlands, Fife: Overlooking Sweno and Cawdor's camp

Enter two Fife Soldiers

FIFAN SOLDIER 1

We had reports their force had split in two;
One here in Fife, the other marched to Forres.
That's surely false, this host we look upon
Must be the largest I have ever seen.

FIFAN SOLDIER 2

It's true, these are but half of Norway's men
The other half has marched to face the King.

FIFAN SOLDIER 1

Well, he has walls to hide behind, at least.
Macduff must not have known their army's size
To call us up to fight them in the field.

FIFAN SOLDIER 2

This must be ten to one.

FIFAN SOLDIER 1

Nay, twenty, sure.

Enter Macduff and Ross

FIFAN SOLDIER 2

The Thane of Fife intends to prove his mettle,
His father's memory taunts this boldness out.

He taught his son to seek out glory, but
I fear he failed to teach him how to count.

MACDUFF

You're partly right.

FIFAN SOLDIER 2

My lord!

FIFAN SOLDIER 1

My worthy thane.

MACDUFF

I do intend to show our enemy proof,
A proof that men of Fife will not allow
Their land and home to serve as barn and barracks
For traitors and invaders. As for numbers,
My father did indeed give me instruction
On how to judge the body of your foe.
You must not simply look upon his size
And, if you are found wanting, turn and run;
The canny soldier tallies up the difference
Accounting for preparedness and skill.
They cannot comprehend their own defeat
And this is how defeat will fall upon them.
Their arrogance, inflated by their numbers,
Has told them they can send Macdonwald on,
Assuming that no challenge could be made.
I pray you take a closer look upon them -
Their carts are laden, weapons packed away;
They are prepared for travel not for war,
But travelling war has caught them unprepared.
We've all heard tell of Sweno's army's size,
Their numbers fearsome even cleft in twain,
But I would rather take one man alone,
Who's braced his body and his spirit, ready
In every way a man can be to fight,
O'er fifty who had ope'd their eyes this morning
Not knowing of the horrors they would see.
And, like a shadow cast upon the wall,
Surprise, the soldier's bosom friend, will swell
Our army's bulk and so will help us scour
These rebels and these Norse invaders hence.
Think not of men in Forres who must crouch

Behind their castle walls and pray their foe
In boredom, tears himself apart to spare
Their shaking swords from striking out at him.
You men of Fife, you need no walls of stone
You have it in your bones, you need no barrels
Of bubbling tar, I see your steaming souls,
They simmer in your armour and I know
That when we charge upon this bloated beast,
That when this scalding pitch is pouring forth,
Your enemy will feel his body blister,
His searing sword will slip his slackened grip,
And in his terror, trampled by his fellows,
Who flee before your fury, will be flattened,
His brittle body buried in the mud.
The victory which we will win today
Will be the envy of all those in Forres,
Of every loyal subject left in Scotland
And every man with nerve to hold a sword
Who dares to call himself a warrior.
So now, with me, and let us show them Fife
Will not be bought for less than Sweno's life!

Exeunt

Act 5, Scene 2 - Highlands: Forres Castle Battlements

Enter Lennox, above.

Enter Banquo.

BANQUO
Lennox, you called for me?

LENNOX
The enemy
Approaches and we think they come to parley.

Enter below, Harthacnut, Macdonwald with Malcolm, bound, and Rebel and Norse Soldiers.

HARTHACNUT
All those inside King Duncan's keep, now hear:
I offer you your lives. You see we have
His eldest son in chains and offer you

The chance to set him free and free yourselves
From death and misery. Bring Duncan forth!

LENNOX

They do not lie, that's Malcolm.

BANQUO

Tell the King.

Exit Lennox

MALCOLM

Macdonwald, tell me, now the time has come;
How do you plan to spring the Viking's trap?

MACDONWALD

What says the mewling runt?

MALCOLM

I am intrigued,
To see how you'll escape the fate divined
By your position here, so trapped between
Norwegian soldiers and King Duncan's walls.
Only a man so bold as you could make
A gambit such as this.

MACDONWALD

Your father talked
In riddles too, speak plain.

MALCOLM

What is your plan?
You barely have two hundred rebels left,
Outnumbered vastly by the Viking horde
Who soon will turn against you. I have tried
Imagining the board from your perspective
To figure out the move you plan to make,
Despite my efforts though, I seem to be
Th'inferior tactician.

MACDONWALD

Do you think
This Viking dares to dream of treachery?
His King has placed his men in my command.

MALCOLM

Macdonwald, surely you do not believe
That Cawdor, Sweno and his brother wish
To see you crowned a King?

MACDONWALD

I'm stronger than
All three of them together, there's no question.

MALCOLM

The only strength you have is suckled from
Your Viking masters' breast. If they had not
Allowed your mouth to clamp around their teat,
And rather left you bawling in the wild,
How long would you have lasted? They have used
Your men as pawns, the Viking laughed aloud
And marvelled at your foolishness, when he
Was gloating to his men, but I assumed,
That one as shrewd as you would have seen through
The hood he had you wear. Alas, it seems
The chorus of your history repeats;
My father used you, Cawdor used you, now
These Norsemen whom swore you would destroy,
Have used you too.

HARTHACNUT

Macdonwald, bring the boy.
King Duncan needs to see that he's alive
If he is to agree to bargain.

MALCOLM

Hark,
Your master calls you.

MACDONWALD

Viking, draw your blade,
And I will show you how a bargain's made.

HARTHACNUT

So turns the rabid cur. Now, Men of Norway!
Let's rid us of this scum!

Macdonwald attacks Harthacnut. The Rebel Soldiers fight the Norse Soldiers.

Enter Sergeant

SERGEANT

Come Malcolm, do not struggle, look at me!

MALCOLM

I know you.

SERGEANT

Aye, now let me cut your bonds.

Stay close to me and do not leave my side.

And through this broil I will be your guide.

Exit Sergeant and Malcolm

Enter above Lennox, Duncan, Donalbain and Macbeth

DUNCAN

My son? My Malcolm, where is he? My boy!

LENNOX

I saw him sire, bound below but now

I cannot spy him in the fray.

DUNCAN

Malcolm!

BANQUO

The heat of war has cracked the brittle glass
In which was poured the wine of this alliance.

An opportunity to break the siege

Has come upon us. We must take them now

Before a winning side emerges. Sire,

You must be gone from here to safety. Lennox,

We're opening the gates, escort the King

Along the corridor I told you of

And guard him with your life.

LENNOX

It will be done.

DUNCAN

I will not leave my son!

If you are killed,
We will be left in ruin. Macbeth and I
Will find your son. Now go - Lennox!

Exit Lennox and Duncan

Exeunt

GUNHILDA

Almost

Impossible without some steering spectre
Advising them to seize on this advantage.

Alarum

CAWDOR

I hear them coming, lady, you must shed
Your brother's warlike visage and put on
A simple maiden's aspect. I will say
You are a gift King Sweno gave to me,
A serving girl I took a liking to,
I'll offer information in exchange
For both our lives. Then we could find a place
For you in Scotland -

GUNHILDA

And, at last, I see

The trickster Loki's face.

CAWDOR

What do you mean?

GUNHILDA

You never left King Duncan's side.

CAWDOR

You think

I had a hand in this assault?

GUNHILDA

How else

Can several hundred strike against ten-thousand?
You played my harpstrings well, just as I feared
But don't insult my wisdom now.

CAWDOR

Gunhilda

There's no time, if they find -

GUNHILDA

You killed my brothers.

CAWDOR

I can protect you if you listen -

GUNHILDA

No.

I've listened long enough. You can protect me,
And find a place for me in Scotland? Leashed,
Obediently sitting at your feet:

The Thane of Cawdor's tamèd Viking whore,
His living plunder, won in war. If you
Desire a trophy, come and hack my head
From off my neck and mount it on your wall.

She draws her sword.

CAWDOR

I will not fight you.

GUNHILDA

We've been fighting, Scotsman,
Since first we met, if only I had known it.
I will not sully Sweno's warlike name
With cowardly retreat. I'll see him soon,
And I intend to look him in the eye.

She attacks. Cawdor is disarmed. Gunhilda is poised to lay a mortal blow.

Enter Macduff, Ross, Fifan Soldiers 1 & 2 and Soldiers

CAWDOR

My worthy Thanes of Fife and Ross.

MACDUFF

Cawdor.

ROSS

You're indisposed, it seems.

MACDUFF

Is this King Sweno?

CAWDOR

This is -

GUNHILDA

I am and I applaud the ambush
You've orchestrated here. Once I have had
My just revenge against your spy, I will
Give you your chance to claim a place in history
As those who sent King Sweno to Valhalla.

MACDUFF

Sweno thinks Cawdor is a spy? What if
He still serves Duncan?

ROSS

It's possible, if so
Then Duncan wouldn't want him dead. We must
Return him to the King in chains with Sweno.

GUNHILDA

The only chains I'll wear are those you'll wrap
Around my ruined corpse, if you are wise,
To stop the vengeful Draugr I'll become
From tearing off your heads.

MACDUFF

Lay on then -

CAWDOR

Stop.

Macduff, I am no spy. King Sweno thinks
That I've betrayed him and his people, but
In truth, I have betrayed you all. The offer
That Sweno made for peace was true and I
Have twisted it to my design in hopes
That I might use his army as my own
To take the Scottish throne. I beg you, please,
Take me in chains, put me to death, but spare
The King of Norway, he can end this war.
You have a strong negotiating arm,
I know that Sweno still desires peace;
He could return to Norway and his home,
And leave the ghosts of those he's lost behind.

ROSS

Forgive me, Sweno King, you do not have
The look of one who longs for peace.

CAWDOR

If you

Can grant him burial of his men -

MACDUFF

Their flesh

Will rot above the earth -

ROSS

Until he fills

King Duncan's coffers, compensating him
And all of Scotland for the woes he's caused.
Then we will grant him burial of his dead
And passage out of Scotland with his living.
What says King Sweno to this proposition?

GUNHILDA

Too many of my brothers ne'er will look
Again upon the sloping stones of home
Which rise up on the edge of Norway's shores,
Or on the mounds which house their fathers' bones.
You Scots can have your silver but my men
Will not be buried in your stinking peat.
I'll bear them off to sea so that their souls
Might be delivered freely to Valhalla.
I'll tell my fighters to submit, and then
No Scot will see King Sweno's face again.

Exit Gunhilda

ROSS

Let word ring out that Cawdor has been captured
And Sweno sues for peace.

Exit Fife Soldier 2

Now, I will ride

To tell the King of victory in Fife -
And what a tale I'll have to share with him;
Each Scotsman stood against a score of Norse,
And now bear triumph's torch.

MACDUFF

I hope you find
This light reflected back at you in Forres.

ROSS

I'll tell him of your leadership and paint
The picture boldly. Once it is beheld,
If Duncan doesn't grant you Cawdor's title,
A great injustice will it be on you.

Exit Ross. Enter Fifan Soldier 2 with a missive.

MACDUFF

It's as you said, your men lay down their arms.
The Norsemen all give way. You are defeated.
You will be borne to Castle Fife in chains
And there we'll wait for Duncan's final sentence.

CAWDOR

If Duncan still is King then I suspect
He'll speak the bleakest sentence words can form.

Exeunt

Act 5, Scene 4 - Highlands: The Battle Outside Forres

Enter Macdonwald

MACDONWALD

The Viking rats have fled the sinking ship.
Where to, I do not care, save that I'll miss
My chance to flay their worthless hides myself.

Enter Malcolm

MALCOLM

Turn, mad dog, turn.

MACDONWALD

Of all men else,
I relish meeting you, my little prince.
What death would please you, sire? Shall I wait
Until the very end to take your eyes,
Or would you rather spare yourself the sight

They fight. Macbeth unseams Macdonwald from the navel to the chops and cuts off his head.

MACBETH

I need no words for you, my sword is all.

Enter Banquo

BANQUO

Macdonwald?

MACBETH

Aye.

Alarum

BANQUO

Go, fix his head upon the battlements,
His men will scatter when they learn of this.
I know not where the Norsemen are.

SERGEANT

Lord Banquo.

BANQUO

You're wounded, Sergeant.

SERGEANT

Aye, but not as bad

As he who wounded me. But mark me, sir,
The Norway's lord has made a swift retreat
And will return with fresh supplies of men,
Who wait upon a far-off heath.

BANQUO

We'll ride

And meet them ere they turn the bloody tide.
Have you the strength to guide us there?

SERGEANT

I do.

BANQUO

Come, then. Macbeth?

Just point me towards a foe that I can slay.
I'll ne'er wash off the blood I'll spill this day.

Act 5, Scene 5 - Lowlands: Fife, a prison

I believed
The King no longer cared about his kingdom
And, as I'd spent my life in Scotland's service

Act 5, Scene 6 - Highlands: A blasted heath not far from Forres

Enter Harthacnut

HARTHACNUT

I wished to see the mountains of my home
Before I saw Valhalla's. I know not where
Gunhilda and the Thane of Cawdor are.
Their numbers now were meant to swell our own.
I left my men beyond the castle's reach
But hounds have caught our scent and are upon us.
It is no matter, we are born to die
And if my death must come, I will not flinch
Nor give my enemy a single inch.

Enter Macbeth, Banquo and the Sergeant, wounded

BANQUO

Is this the Norweyan Lord?

SERGEANT

Aye, sir. He's fierce
I've seen him cut down thirty men, at least.

BANQUO

Go, Sergeant, find the King, for if we die
He will not know that Malcolm lives. His camp
Is out beyond the castle. Go, your wounds
Will not long let you stand.

SERGEANT

There's but one horse
Which has survived our bloody charge.

BANQUO

Then take it,
And tell the King of what has happened here.
He will have surgeons with him in his camp.

Exit Sergeant

HARTHACNUT

What are your names?

BANQUO

Banquo of Lochaber,
This is Macbeth, the Thane of Glamis.

HARTHACNUT

I am
Harthacnut, the brother of the King.

BANQUO

You tell us this in hope we'll take you ransom?

HARTHACNUT

I simply tell you so the skalds may know
The ending of my story in these lands.
Lay on then, both, it's fitting it should be
A pair of Scots who were the death of me.

Macbeth, Banquo and Harthacnut fight. Harthacnut is slain.

BANQUO

May Scotland finally slumber sound and free.
Macbeth, I know your pain still throbs within you,
But time will bring you solace, I am sure.
I've never seen a soldier fight like you have,
It was as though you knew you couldn't die.

MACBETH

Alas, I stand, unbested and unslain.

BANQUO

There's much left in this life that yet might save
The wound you bear inside your heart. Come on,
Let's leave this blasted heath and so begone.

Exeunt

Act 5, Scene 7 - Duncan's Camp, near Forres

Enter Duncan, Donalbain, Lennox and attendants

LENNOX

Keep close, the mist descends and could conceal

Attackers who may wish you deadly harm.

DONALBAIN

And when it rises how might Scotland look?

LENNOX

How does the King?

DONALBAIN

The sight of Malcolm shook him.

He was as good as dead to him before,

But now he knows that Malcolm ne'er was traitor,

He fears that he has lost him o'er again.

DUNCAN

(Aside)

This is the place the Weird Sisters met me,

I hear their wretched voices in the fog,

Their darkened shapes emerge, becoming thicker

With every forward step.

LENNOX

Who's there? What, ho?

Enter Malcolm

MALCOLM

A friend! I serve the King!

DUNCAN

Malcolm.

The blighted spirits do not cheat my eyes?

MALCOLM

O father! Sire, here: upon my knees

I fall and will stand not again until

I've wrested mercy and forgiveness from you.

I thought I knew the Thane of Cawdor, sir,

I thought him loyal to you and so sought

To save you from an act of self-impairment

By liberating him from Forres' dungeon.

But Cawdor was a traitor, sire, I saw him,

Colluding with Macdonwald and the Norsemen

DUNCAN

You saw him? Where?

MALCOLM

I ventured to their camp.

I'd hoped to prove my loyalty to you
By bringing you Macdonwald's severed head,
But I was caught and captured i'the attempt.
A norse lord chose to keep me prisoner;
To trade my life for your surrender, but
A loyal sergeant freed me from my bonds
And bade me flee the battle.

DUNCAN

Oh my boy,

Courageous, if not reckless; had I known
The peril you were mired in, I doubt
I could have stopped myself from riding out
And freeing you myself, my creaking bones
Compressed and encased in ancient armour.
You've done me proud, but now I beg of you:
Please, never leave my side again.

MALCOLM

I won't.

DUNCAN

But have you any knowledge of the battle?
Has victory been claimed by either side?

MALCOLM

I know not, father, it was blood and chaos.
I took my chance to flee ere it was won.

Enter Sergeant

DUNCAN

What bloody man is that? He can report,
As seemeth by his plight, of the revolt
The newest state.

MALCOLM

This is the Sergeant

Who, like a good and hardy soldier, fought
'Gainst my captivity. Hail, brave friend!
Say to the King the knowledge of the broil
As thou didst leave it.

SERGEANT

Doubtful it stood,
As two spent swimmers that do cling together
And choke their art. The merciless Macdonwald,
Worthy to be a rebel, for to that
The multiplying villainies of nature
Do swarm upon him, from the Western Isles
Of kerns and gallowglasses is supplied;
And Fortune, on his damnèd quarrel smiling,
Showed like a rebel's whore. But all's too weak;
For brave Macbeth, well he deserves that name,
Disdaining Fortune, with his brandished steel,
Which smoked with bloody execution,
Like Valor's minion, carved out his passage
Till he faced the slave;
Which ne'er shook hands, nor bade farewell to him,
Till he unseamed him from the nave to th' chops,
And fixed his head upon our battlements.

DUNCAN

O valiant cousin, worthy gentleman!

SERGEANT

As whence the sun 'gins his reflection
Shipwracking storms and direful thunders break,
So from that spring whence comfort seemed to come
Discomfort swells. Mark, King of Scotland, mark:
No sooner justice had, with valour armed,
Compelled these skipping kerns to trust their heels,
But the Norweyan lord, surveying vantage,
With furbished arms and new supplies of men,
Began a fresh assault.

DUNCAN

Dismayed not this
Our captains, Macbeth and Banquo?

SERGEANT

Yes,

As sparrows, eagles, or the hare the lion.
If I say sooth, I must report they were
As cannons overcharged with double cracks,
So they doubly redoubled strokes upon the foe.
Except they meant to bathe in reeking wounds
Or memorise another Golgotha, I cannot tell.
But I am faint. My gashes cry for help.

DUNCAN

So well thy words become thee as thy wounds:
They smack of honour both. Go, get him surgeons.

The Sergeant is led off by attendants.

Enter Ross

DUNCAN

Who comes here?

MALCOLM

The worthy Thane of Ross.

LENNOX

What a haste looks through his eyes! So should he look
That seems to speak things strange.

ROSS

God save the King.

DUNCAN

Whence cam'st thou, worthy thane?

ROSS

From Fife, great King,

Where the Norweyan banners flout the sky
And fan our people cold.
Norway himself, with terrible numbers,
Assisted by that most disloyal traitor,
The Thane of Cawdor, began a dismal conflict,
Till that Bellona's bridegroom, lapped in proof,
Confronted him with self-comparisons,
Point against point, rebellious arm 'gainst arm,
Curbing his lavish spirit. And to conclude,
The victory fell on us.

DUNCAN

Great happiness!

ROSS

That now Sweno,
The Norways' king, craves composition.
Nor would we deign him burial of his men
Till he disbursèd at Saint Colme's Inch
Ten thousand dollars to our general use.

DUNCAN

No more that Thane of Cawdor shall deceive
Our bosom interest. Go, pronounce his present death,
And with his former title, greet Macbeth.

ROSS

I'll see it done.

DUNCAN

What he hath lost, noble Macbeth hath won.

Exeunt

Act 5, Scene 8 - The Glen/Forres/Fife

Enter the Sisters, Malcolm and Duncan

FIRST SISTER

When shall we three meet again?

DUNCAN

Is execution done on Cawdor?
Are not those in commission yet returned?

FIRST SISTER

In thunder, lightning, or in rain?

MALCOLM

My liege,

Enter Cawdor, with an executioner.

They are not yet come back. But I have spoke
With one that saw him die, who did report:

SECOND SISTER

When the hurly-burly's done,

MALCOLM

That very frankly he confessed his treasons,
Implored your Highness' pardon, and set forth
A deep repentance.

SECOND SISTER

When the battle's lost and won.

MALCOLM

Nothing in his life
Became him like the leaving it. He died

Cawdor kneels.

THIRD SISTER

That will be ere the set of sun.

MALCOLM

As one that had been studied in his death

Cawdor lays his head on the block.

FIRST SISTER

Where the place?

MALCOLM

To throw away the dearest thing he owed
As 'twere a careless trifle.

SECOND SISTER

Upon the heath.

DUNCAN

There's no art
To find the mind's construction in the face.
He was a gentleman on whom I built

The executioner stands next to Cawdor

THIRD SISTER
There to meet with

DUNCAN
An absolute trust.

The executioner raises his axe

THREE SISTERS
Macbeth.

Exeunt